

JESUS — OF — NAZARETH

A Chronological Account of His Life and Teachings



Volume I:

From Eternity to the Threshold of Ministry

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Volume I

From Eternity to the Threshold of His Ministry

English Edition

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This book is an original work of historical, theological, and chronological research based on the biblical Scriptures, texts from Second Temple Judaism, historical sources from the ancient world, and contemporary academic studies. It is not intended to replace the biblical texts nor to impose a specific doctrinal interpretation. Biblical citations are used for academic, historical, and explanatory purposes.

First English edition.

DEDICATION AND PREFACE

To my father,

Sergio Salgado Luna.

Who has followed God faithfully for several decades. His quiet, steady, and persevering walk has been a form of teaching deeper than any words. This work exists, in part, because there was a life that chose faith even when the path was not easy.

This book is born from a profound conviction: that the life of Jesus of Nazareth cannot be fully understood through isolated fragments. His story, His context, and His meaning form a unity that must be read with attention, patience, and reverence.

Throughout the centuries, countless works have been written about Jesus. Some have been devotional, others historical, others theological. This project seeks to integrate these dimensions into a coherent, rigorous, and accessible chronological narrative, allowing the reader to situate themselves within the real world in which these events took place.

Volume I covers the period from the Old Testament promises to the beginning of Jesus' public ministry. It does not seek to offer definitive answers to every question, but rather to provide a solid framework from which the reader may better understand the Gospel accounts.

This work is addressed both to believers and non-believers, to scholars and to sincere readers who seek to understand not only what happened, but also why it happened, and how these events have profoundly shaped human history.

Volume 1: The Early Years of Jesus Christ – Prophecy to Preparation

Introduction

The life of Yeshua (Jesus) the Messiah is one of the most studied and revered subjects in history, encompassing theological, historical, and cultural dimensions. This multi-volume work offers a chronological, academic, and in-depth approach, integrating the biblical narratives with historical sources and archaeological findings, as well as theological interpretations from different traditions (Catholic, Protestant, Orthodox, and Messianic). Volume I covers the period from the ancient Messianic prophecies to the beginning of Yeshua's public ministry, including His genealogies, His miraculous birth, His childhood, and preparation. Original names are used—such as Yeshua instead of Jesus, Jehovah to refer to God, and titles such as Messiah—to preserve historical and cultural fidelity. Each chapter includes detailed references to Scripture and historical documents, concise summaries, and suggestions for visual elements (timelines, maps, diagrams) to facilitate understanding. The volume concludes with an appendix compiling all the biblical verses cited about Yeshua and Jehovah throughout the text.

Objectives and Approach: This project seeks to go beyond a traditional narrative by examining the life of Yeshua from an interdisciplinary perspective. It will address the biblical prophecies that foretold His coming, showing how they were understood and fulfilled; analyze His genealogies in the Gospels and their theological significance; describe the historical and cultural context of first-century Judea—a world under Roman rule, marked by Jewish pluralism and Messianic expectation; and recount the key episodes of Yeshua's infancy and youth, from the announcement of His birth to His public presentation through baptism in the Jordan River, His temptation in the wilderness, and His first disciples and miracles. Along the way, the work integrates the voices of ancient historians (such as Flavius Josephus and Cornelius Tacitus) who attest to facts about Yeshua, discoveries such as the Dead Sea Scrolls that illuminate the Messianic mindset of His time, and the theological perspectives of various faith communities regarding these events. The result is a rich and nuanced portrait of the early years of the Messiah, accessible to scholars, believers, and general readers alike.

Chronological Timeline — Volume I



Editorial Note: This timeline presents approximate dates based on historical consensus and biblical analysis. Its purpose is to orient the reader within a coherent chronological sequence, not to impose a rigid chronology.

Chapter 1: Ancient Prophecies of the Messiah

From centuries before the birth of Yeshua, the Hebrew Scriptures announced the coming of a Messiah (Anointed One) who would redeem His people. These Messianic prophecies formed the central hope of Israel and prepared the way for understanding Yeshua's mission. In this chapter, we will explore some of the principal biblical prophecies concerning the Messiah and how the Christian tradition sees them fulfilled in Jesus of Nazareth. Brief mention will also be made of Jewish interpretations that differ, highlighting the contrast of perspectives regarding who the promised Messiah is.

1.1 The Promise of a Descendant of David Who Will Reign Forever

Jehovah promised to raise up an eternal king from the line of David. The prophet Jeremiah, for example, declared: "Behold, the days are coming, says Jehovah, when I will raise to David a righteous Branch; He shall reign as King and prosper, and execute judgment and righteousness in the earth." This "Branch" would be a legitimate descendant of David who would bring salvation to Judah and Israel and would be called "Jehovah Our Righteousness."

Jewish hope in the time of Yeshua included the restoration of the Davidic throne. The Gospels emphasize that Jesus fulfills this Messianic profile by being of the house of David (see the genealogies in Chapter 2) and by being proclaimed King (for example, in His entry into Jerusalem or by the title "Son of David" given to Him by the crowds). Isaiah 9:6–7 likewise speaks of a child born to reign with justice upon the throne of David forever, called Wonderful, Mighty God, Prince of Peace. Early Christians applied these images to Yeshua, especially after His resurrection, seeing Him enthroned to reign without end.

1.2 The Place of Birth — Bethlehem

The prophet Micah precisely foretold the town where the Messiah would be born: "But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah, though you are little among the clans of Judah, out of you shall come forth to Me the One to be Ruler in Israel, whose goings forth are from of old, from everlasting." This announcement in Micah 5:2 placed the cradle of the future King in the village of Bethlehem, the hometown of King David.

In the Gospel of Matthew, when the magi from the East arrive seeking the newborn "King of the Jews," the chief priests and scribes cite Micah 5:2 to inform King Herod that the Messiah was to be born in Bethlehem of Judea. Early Christians viewed Yeshua's birth in Bethlehem as a direct fulfillment of this prophecy. It is noteworthy that Bethlehem was an insignificant town, highlighting the contrast between the humility of the Messiah's coming and the greatness of His mission—a recurring theme in Christian theology.

1.3 The Birth of a Virgin — The Sign of Immanuel

One of the most notable Messianic prophecies is found in Isaiah 7:14: "Therefore the Lord Himself will give you a sign: Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son and shall call His name Immanuel." The Hebrew term 'almáh used by Isaiah refers to a young woman of

marriageable age, and the ancient Greek Septuagint (LXX) explicitly translated it as Parthenos (virgin).

The Gospel of Matthew cites this prophecy to explain the miraculous birth of Yeshua from the virgin Miriam (Mary), affirming that He is “Immanuel,” meaning “God with us” (Matthew 1:22–23). For Christian faith, the virgin birth of Jesus testifies to His divine nature and to supernatural intervention in history.

The Catholic Church and the Orthodox Church developed from this a profound Marian doctrine, venerating Mary as Theotokos (“Mother of God”) and affirming her perpetual virginity, while Protestant theologians have traditionally emphasized the prophetic fulfillment and the uniqueness of Christ more than the person of Mary. Classical Jewish interpretation, on the other hand, does not regard Isaiah 7:14 as a Messianic prophecy, understanding it instead as referring to a child born in the time of King Ahaz. Nevertheless, from the Christian and Messianic perspective, this verse is foundational in supporting the Incarnation: God entering the world in human form, born of a young virgin woman through the work of the Holy Spirit.

1.4 A Messenger Will Prepare the Way

Malachi and other prophets spoke of a precursor who would go before the Anointed One. Malachi 3:1 records the divine promise: “Behold, I send My messenger, and he will prepare the way before Me...” Likewise, Isaiah 40:3 proclaims: “The voice of one crying in the wilderness: Prepare the way of Jehovah; make straight in the desert a highway for our God.”

These words relate directly to the appearance of John the Baptist in the wilderness of Judea centuries later, preaching repentance and announcing the imminent coming of the Kingdom of God. The New Testament identifies John as that prophesied messenger (Matthew 3:1–3; Mark 1:2–4), a figure in the spirit of Elijah who was to come (Malachi 4:5–6). Jesus Himself affirmed that John was the Elijah who was to come to restore all things (Matthew 11:10–14).

Thus, John’s activity—his call to conversion and his baptism of repentance in the Jordan—was understood by the evangelists as fulfillment of ancient promises: before the Messiah would be revealed, God would send His herald to “prepare the way.” This aspect will be explored in greater detail in Chapter 7, when addressing the baptism of Yeshua.

1.5 Light to the Nations, Healer of the Oppressed

Several prophecies describe the mission of the Servant of Jehovah or the Messiah as a light to all peoples and as an agent of healing and liberation. Isaiah 49:6 declares: “I will also give You as a light to the nations, that You should be My salvation to the ends of the earth.” Likewise, Isaiah 35 portrays the Messianic age as a time when “the eyes of the blind shall be opened... the ears of the deaf unstopped... the lame shall leap like a deer, and the tongue of the mute sing.”

Jesus of Nazareth, in His public ministry, fulfilled precisely these signs: according to the Gospels, He healed the blind, the deaf, and the lame, cleansed lepers, and even raised the dead. When John the Baptist, from prison, sent messengers to ask whether Jesus was the One to come, Jesus responded by mentioning these works (Luke 7:22), pointing to Isaiah's prophecies as evidence of His Messiahship.

Indeed, a manuscript found among the Dead Sea Scrolls (4Q521), known as the "Messianic Apocalypse," reflects that in the first century B.C., some Jews expected the Messiah to perform exactly these miracles: "He will heal the severely wounded and make the deadline, proclaim good news to the meek..." This demonstrates that the understanding of Isaiah as announcing a healing Messiah was present in the contemporary environment of Jesus, and early Christians saw His miracles as clear prophetic confirmation.

1.6 Other Relevant Prophecies

Messianic expectation included many other Scriptures. For example, the patriarch Jacob prophesied that the scepter would not depart from the tribe of Judah until "Shiloh" came (Genesis 49:10), interpreted by some as an allusion to the ruling Messiah arising from Judah—the tribe of David and of Yeshua.

The pagan seer Balaam uttered an intriguing prophecy: "A star shall come out of Jacob; a scepter shall rise out of Israel" (Numbers 24:17), known as the Prophecy of the Star of Jacob. Many associate this with the star that guided the wise men from the East at the birth of Jesus; indeed, some Jewish apocryphal texts of the period also interpreted the appearance of a bright star as a sign of the Messiah's birth. The Gospel of Matthew appears to allude to this tradition when recounting the star of Bethlehem guiding the magi, which ancient theologians considered a fulfillment of Balaam's prophecy.

Moreover, prophecies such as those of the Suffering Servant in Isaiah 53, or those of Zechariah (who speaks of the humble king riding on a donkey, Zechariah 9:9, and of betrayal for "thirty pieces of silver," Zechariah 11:12–13), find resonance in the passion of Christ. Although these events belong to the final stage of Yeshua's life (Volume II of this work), it is important to note that early Christian interpretation identified more than 300 prophecies fulfilled in Jesus. This reinforced the conviction of the first disciples (who were Messianic Jews) that Jesus of Nazareth was the Messiah promised by God, despite popular expectations of a political leader.

In contrast, Judaism contemporary to Jesus and later rabbinic Judaism generally did not recognize in Him the Messianic fulfillment, since they expected, for example, a triumphant Messiah who would liberate Israel from Roman rule and establish worldwide peace. This divergence ultimately led to distinct religious paths. The richness of the Messianic prophecies, therefore, is appreciated differently depending on the perspective of faith: for Christians, they are providential proof of Yeshua's identity as the Christ; for many Jews, those passages must be understood in their original context and do not necessarily point to Jesus.

Chapter 1 Summary

- In this chapter, we have reviewed the principal Old Testament prophecies concerning the Messiah and how Yeshua fulfilled them according to Christian faith. We highlighted His birth in Bethlehem, His birth from a virgin, His belonging to the eternal Davidic lineage, the appearance of a forerunning herald, and the performance of miraculous signs as a “light” to all nations.
- These prophecies nourished hope in the time of Jesus—an era marked by strong Messianic and apocalyptic expectations—and provide an indispensable background for understanding the significance of each event in His life. The convergence between the ancient Scriptures and the life of Yeshua was interpreted as divine confirmation of His mission.
- In the following chapters, we will see how these promises intertwine with the historical reality of the birth and early life of Jesus.



Chapter 2: Historical and Cultural Context of Jesus's Birth

One of the first elements the Gospels present about Yeshua is His genealogy—His family tree—since the identity of the Messiah was tied to His lineage. The genealogies demonstrate that Jesus fulfilled the Messianic requirements of descent: He had to come from Abraham, the father of the people of Israel, and be an heir of King David.

In the New Testament we find two genealogies of Jesus: one in the Gospel of Matthew (1:1–17) and another in the Gospel of Luke (3:23–38). These lists of ancestors, while sharing certain points, also present significant differences in structure and names, which have generated theological and historical analysis. In this chapter we will examine the characteristics of each genealogy, their theological meaning, and the classical explanations of their divergences, incorporating Catholic, Protestant, Orthodox, and Messianic perspectives.

2.1 The Genealogy According to Matthew — Jesus, Son of Abraham and Son of David

The Gospel according to Matthew opens directly with the phrase: “The book of the genealogy of Jesus Christ, the son of David, the son of Abraham” (Matt. 1:1). Matthew traces the ancestral line from Abraham to Jesus, underscoring the connection to David. He organizes the names into three groups of fourteen generations each, a possibly symbolic structure: in Hebrew numerology, the name “David” has a numerical value of 14, and thus this arrangement highlights Jesus as the Davidic King par excellence.

Matthew includes five women in his list—Tamar, Rahab, Ruth, Bathsheba (referred to as “the wife of Uriah”), and Mary—something unusual in ancient genealogies. All of them, except Mary, were Gentiles or were involved in uncommon circumstances; their presence underscores God’s grace working through the unexpected and anticipates the inclusion of the Gentiles in salvation.

At the end of the list, Matthew declares: “Jacob begot Joseph the husband of Mary, of whom was born Jesus, who is called the Christ” (Matt. 1:16). This carefully formulated phrase attributes legal fatherhood to Joseph while indicating that Jesus was born of Mary (suggesting the virgin birth). For Matthew, demonstrating that Yeshua is son of Abraham (heir of the promise made to the father of faith) and son of David (legitimate Messianic king) is crucial, his genealogy functions as Messianic credentials.

Theologically, Catholic and Orthodox communities have reflected on this list by emphasizing how God guided salvation history through generations—marked by both light and shadow—until the fullness of time in Christ. Ancient Church authors such as Jerome noted the presence of converted sinners (Tamar, Rahab) in the genealogy as a sign of the universal mercy Jesus would bring. Protestant interpreters often focus on prophetic fulfillment: Jesus fulfills the promise to Abraham (to bless all nations) and the Davidic promise of an eternal throne.

2.2 The Genealogy According to Luke — Jesus, the New Adam, Son of God

The Gospel of Luke presents Jesus' genealogy not at the beginning, but after His baptism, when His divine sonship is publicly declared ("You are My beloved Son..." Luke 3:22). Immediately afterward, Luke lists Jesus' ancestors, tracing backward from Joseph to Adam, ending with "the son of God" (Luke 3:23–38).

Thus, Luke emphasizes that Jesus is connected to all humanity, not only to Israel: He is descended from Adam and, in that sense, brother to all humankind, destined to bring universal salvation. In Luke's list, Joseph is mentioned as "the son of Heli," in contrast to Matthew, who calls him the son of Jacob. Luke also includes many names different from Matthew's in the segment between David and Joseph; in Luke, Jesus descends from David through Nathan (another son of David) rather than through Solomon (the royal line).

This notable difference has led to various explanations. An early theory proposed by Christian authors such as Sextus Julius Africanus and later cited by Augustine is that Luke is actually tracing Mary's genealogy, while Matthew traces Joseph's. According to this hypothesis, Heli would be Mary's father, and Joseph, as his son-in-law, would be counted as his "son." In this way, Luke would present Jesus' biological ancestry (through Mary), and Matthew His legal ancestry (through Joseph).

However, Luke does not explicitly mention Mary in the list, and the text states that Jesus was "as was supposed, the son of Joseph, the son of Heli..." (Luke 3:23), suggesting that Luke is also presenting Joseph's legal line, albeit with different names.

Another classical explanation involves the levirate marriage law. Matthew states that "Jacob begot Joseph," while Luke says "Joseph, son of Heli" without specifying "begot." It may be that Jacob and Heli were brothers; Heli died childless, and Jacob married his widow, begetting Joseph, who would legally be Heli's son and biologically Jacob's. This type of levirate marriage (according to Deuteronomy 25:5–6) was recognized to preserve offspring for a deceased brother. Thus, Joseph would have had two fathers: one legal (Heli) and one biological (Jacob). This hypothesis attempted from early Christianity onward to harmonize the genealogies historically. Nevertheless, it does not resolve all discrepancies, since the differences in names span many generations, not only Joseph's.

Some modern proposals suggest that Matthew may have omitted names (forming symmetrical groups of fourteen), while Luke preserved a more complete line, or that one genealogy reflects dynastic succession (kings and legitimate heirs to David's throne) and the other the biological lineage.

2.3 The Theological Meaning of the Genealogies

Beyond technical details, both evangelists communicate important theological messages through the genealogies.

Matthew, writing for an audience familiar with Jewish tradition, emphasizes Jesus as the royal Messiah of Israel: descendant of kings, fulfillment of the Abrahamic and Davidic covenants, coming after a (symbolic) period of preparation reflected in the 3×14 generations (from Abraham to David, from David to the Babylonian exile, and from the exile to Christ). Indeed, Matthew's structure may suggest that Jesus inaugurates the Messianic era following the exile—the fulfillment of hope after long waiting.

Luke, likely writing to Gentiles, connects Jesus to Adam to emphasize that He is Savior of all humanity. By ultimately calling Him “son of God” (Luke 3:38), Luke links His human identity with His divine sonship proclaimed at baptism. Jesus is the “new Adam” who restores what the first Adam lost—an idea later developed by the Apostle Paul (1 Corinthians 15:22, 45).

Messianic Jewish perspectives often value both genealogies as testimonies that Jesus has the right—legally through His paternal line and, according to some interpretations, biologically through His maternal line—to be Mashiach ben David (Messiah, Son of David).

In the Eastern Orthodox tradition, great importance is given to the genealogy read liturgically before Christmas (on the “Sunday of the Forefathers”), celebrating all the righteous of the Old Testament who anticipated Christ. Orthodoxy, drawing also from apocryphal texts such as the Protoevangelium of James, holds that Joachim and Anne (traditionally venerated as Mary's parents) were of Davidic lineage, reinforcing the idea that Mary herself contributed Davidic descent to Jesus. If Mary belonged to a Davidic branch (possibly connected to Heli), then Jesus would biologically be “son of David” from both sides.

Protestant theologians are often open to the hypothesis that Luke preserves Mary's genealogy, since this aligns well with the doctrine of the virgin incarnation (Jesus having Davidic lineage through Mary without a human father). However, there is no absolute consensus, and many simply affirm that both genealogies testify that Jesus fulfills the Messianic credentials, even if all genealogical details are not fully understood today.

2.4 Challenges and Harmonization

As mentioned, the differences in the genealogies have been debated since the earliest centuries. From a historical-critical standpoint, some scholars suggest that theological motives may have shaped the presentation of the data rather than a strict intention to provide an exhaustive list.

Matthew may have adjusted the list into a memorable structure (fourteen generations) by deliberately omitting certain names. Indeed, it is known that Matthew omitted, for example, three kings between Joram and Uzziah possibly to preserve the number fourteen and perhaps because those kings were associated with the wicked Athaliah and the curse on the house of Ahab and thus were not considered worthy of inclusion. This demonstrates that biblical genealogies could be selective, focusing on principal lines.

Luke, on the other hand, includes many more ancestors and extends back to “Adam, son of God,” clearly a theological emphasis. However, Luke mentions names such as Shealtiel and Zerubbabel that are also found in Matthew’s list, indicating that he is recounting the same family but perhaps following a different branch from a certain point onward (Luke through Nathan, son of David; Matthew through Solomon).

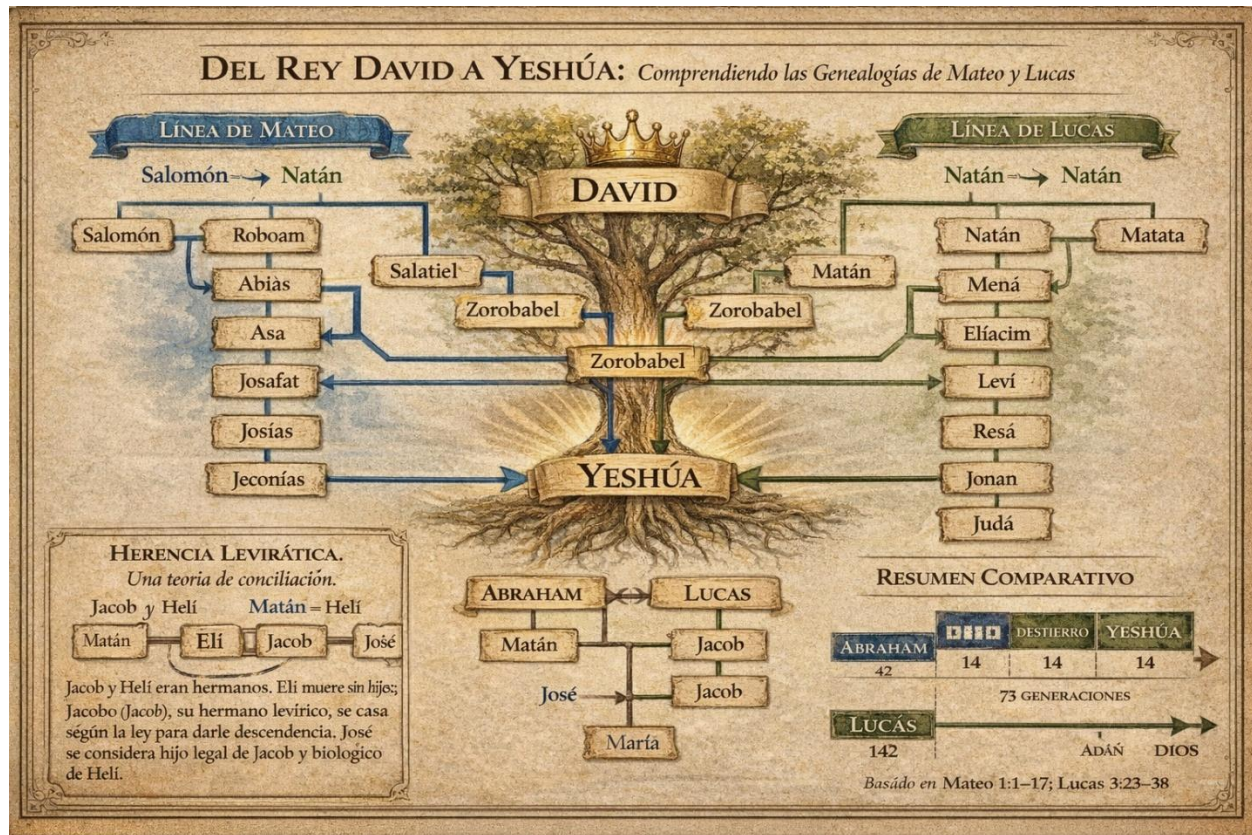
One theory suggests that after the Babylonian exile, due to levirate marriages or adoptions, the two genealogical lines intertwined: Shealtiel and Zerubbabel appear in both lists, after which they diverge again. It is noteworthy that both evangelists converge on Zerubbabel (a leader of the return from Babylonian exile), suggesting familiarity with genealogical records linked to that Davidic family.

From a faith perspective, these apparent complexities do not diminish the central message: Yeshua possesses Messianic legitimacy, belonging to the house of David and the family of Abraham, fulfilling the expected conditions. Both Gospels agree in calling Joseph “son of David” (Matt. 1:20; Luke 1:27), emphasizing that Jesus, as Joseph’s legal son, is also son of David. At the same time, Jesus is conceived by divine action, establishing a new creation while remaining fully inserted into concrete human history.

Chapter 2 Summary

- The genealogies of Yeshua in Matthew and Luke, though different in form, together affirm Jesus’ identity as the promised Messiah: heir of Abraham and David, and at the same time universal Redeemer connected to all humanity from Adam onward.
- Matthew emphasizes Jesus’ royal title as Son of David, organizing history into symbolic periods that culminate in Christ. Luke highlights that Jesus is the Son of God and a new beginning for humanity, tracing His lineage back to the very origin of all.
- Christian traditions have offered harmonizing explanations (for example, the hypothesis that Luke presents Mary’s genealogy, or the levirate marriage explanation regarding Joseph), showing how both lists may complement one another. What is essential is that, in modern terms, Jesus “has Messianic pedigree”: He fulfills the prophecy of coming from the tribe of Judah and the family of David, validating His credentials as the Anointed King.
- In light of this, the first readers of the Gospels would have recognized that they were not being introduced to an upstart, but to the One long awaited in the line of the promises. In the following chapters, we will see how this heritage is manifested in the events surrounding the birth and childhood of Yeshua.

Visual Suggestions



Chapter 3: The Genealogies of Jesus Christ

To fully understand the accounts of Yeshua's birth and early life, it is essential to situate them within their historical and cultural context in the first century Near East. Jesus was born at a specific time and place: the ancient province of Judea, under the rule of the Roman Empire, within a Jewish society marked by political tensions, religious diversity, and distinct spiritual expectations.

In this chapter, we will explore the historical background—including the political situation (rulers, laws, conflicts), the socio-religious diversity within Judaism of the time, and extrabiblical sources that mention Jesus and His environment. This overview will help us appreciate the reality into which the Messiah entered, fulfilling the biblical phrase that He came "in the fullness of time" (Galatians 4:4).

3.1 Judea Under Roman Rule

In the first century B.C. and first century A.D., the land of Israel was under Roman authority. Initially, Rome governed the Jews indirectly through client kings. The most

famous was Herod the Great, appointed “King of Judea” by the Roman Senate, who ruled from 37 to 4 B.C. with an iron hand while carrying out massive construction projects (including the magnificent renovation of the Temple in Jerusalem).

Herod was politically astute but ruthless. Though of Idumean (Edomite) origin, he presented himself as “King of the Jews” with Roman backing. The Gospels place Jesus’ birth “in the days of King Herod” (Matthew 2:1), which establishes a chronology: Herod died in 4 B.C., so Yeshua must have been born before that date, probably between 7 and 5 B.C.

After Herod the Great’s death, his kingdom was divided (the Herodian tetrarchy): Judea, Samaria, and Idumea were placed under his son Archelaus (as ethnarch); Galilee and Perea under Herod Antipas (as tetrarch); and the regions northeast of the Jordan under Philip (another tetrarch).

Archelaus proved incompetent and tyrannical. In A.D. 6, Emperor Augustus deposed him and transformed Judea into a Roman province directly administered by a Roman prefect (or procurator). It is in this context that we later find Pontius Pilate governing Judea during Jesus’ ministry and death (A.D. 26–36). However, during Jesus’ childhood, Galilee remained under Herod Antipas (until A.D. 39), and Judea had just been annexed to Rome.

This political framework explains certain Gospel events. For example, the census of Quirinius mentioned in Luke 2:1–3, which brought Joseph and Mary to Bethlehem for registration, corresponds to the census conducted in Judea around A.D. 6–7 when Rome assumed direct control. This event is attested by the Jewish historian Flavius Josephus, who records that Rome’s annexation of Judea and the tax census provoked a rebellion led by Judas the Galilean.

This chronology presents a challenge, since Jesus was likely born before 4 B.C. under Herod. Scholars have proposed solutions (such as an earlier registration during Herod’s reign, or that Joseph, residing in Galilee under Antipas, may have been required to register in Judea, where his ancestral roots were located). In any case, Roman taxation and census requirements were part of the socio-economic reality people endured. Rome imposed heavy taxes, and this “plague of taxation” had already begun under Herod the Great and continued under his successors, contributing to poverty and intermittent revolts.

Political Map of the Region (4 B.C.–A.D. 6)

This period saw the territorial division after Herod the Great’s death:

- **In yellow:** the ethnarchy of Archelaus (Judea, Samaria, Idumea), which in A.D. 6 became a Roman province under prefects such as Pilate.
- **In green:** the tetrarchy of Herod Antipas (Galilee and Perea), where Jesus grew up and carried out much of His ministry.

- **In purple:** the tetrarchy of Philip (northeast, including Batanea and Trachonitis).
- **In orange:** small regions under Salome (Herod's sister).
- Also indicated is the province of Syria to the north, to which Judea was administratively attached.

Key cities include Bethlehem (birthplace of Yeshua, in Judea), Nazareth (where He was raised, in Galilee), Jerusalem (religious center in Judea), and Sepphoris and Tiberias (Galilean cities with Roman-Hellenistic influence).

Roman domination brought the Pax Romana (a period of relative peace and stability) and improvements in infrastructure (roads, ports) that would later facilitate the spread of the Gospel. Historically speaking, the first century presented ideal conditions: a common language (Koine Greek) had spread throughout the Mediterranean due to the earlier conquests of Alexander the Great, enabling the Christian message to be communicated widely; and Roman political unity, with its secure road systems, allowed early missionaries to travel and disseminate the new faith.

In this sense, believers see the providential hand of God in sending His Son “when the fullness of time had come”—that is, at the historically appropriate moment.

Nevertheless, Roman rule was oppressive in Judea. There were legions and military garrisons (for example, a garrison in Capernaum in Galilee tasked with controlling trade routes), and the presence of Gentile soldiers and imperial symbols was resented by the Jewish population. Tensions occasionally erupted; decades after Jesus, in A.D. 66, fiscal and religious pressures would lead to the Great Jewish Revolt against Rome.

Yet even at the time of Jesus' birth, the seeds of discontent were already present. The angel's proclamation of “peace on earth” (Luke 2:14) to the shepherds in Bethlehem is especially significant in a context where true peace was not achieved through the Roman sword.

3.2 Groups and Sects within First Century Judaism

Jewish society in the Holy Land during the time of Jesus was not monolithic; there were various religious and political groups with distinct beliefs and practices:

- **Pharisees:**

They were a lay movement devoted to strict interpretation of the Law (Torah) and the traditions of the elders. They believed in the resurrection of the dead, in angels and spirits, and sought meticulous observance of ritual purity in daily life. They held significant influence in local synagogues and among the common people. Many scribes (experts in the Law) belonged to the Pharisees.

In the Gospels, Jesus dialogues with and at times strongly debates the Pharisees, since He shared with them a love for God's Law but criticized the hypocrisy or legalism of some. After the fall of the Temple in A.D. 70, the Pharisees would become the precursors of Rabbinic Judaism.

- **Sadducees:**

They were mostly drawn from the priestly and aristocratic class of Jerusalem. They controlled the Temple priesthood and held many seats in the Sanhedrin (the Jewish supreme council). They accepted only the written Torah (the first five books of the Bible) as authoritative, rejecting oral traditions.

They denied doctrines affirmed by the Pharisees, such as the resurrection, the existence of angels, and final reward or punishment. In this sense, they were more theologically conservative. They collaborated more readily with Roman rule to maintain their power and were often viewed as politically accommodating.

In the Gospels, they appear in conflict with Jesus particularly regarding the resurrection (Matthew 22:23–33). After A.D. 70, their influence disappeared with the destruction of the Temple.

- **Essenes:**

Not directly mentioned in the Bible but described by historians such as Josephus and associated with the Qumran manuscripts (Dead Sea Scrolls). They were an ascetic community that likely arose in protest against corruption in the Temple. They lived in the desert near the Dead Sea (such as at Qumran) and in other locations.

They practiced communal living, vows of purity, and anticipated the imminent end of the age, expecting an eschatological battle between the "Sons of Light" and the "Sons of Darkness." They believed they alone preserved the true faith and followed a distinct ritual calendar.

It is possible that John the Baptist was influenced by currents such as those of the Essenes (given his life in the wilderness and emphasis on purification), though this cannot be stated with certainty. The Dead Sea Scrolls reveal theological ideas close in some respects to Christian concepts: they speak of a "Teacher of Righteousness," of the coming of two Messiahs (one priestly and one royal), and, as noted earlier, include prophecies about miracles the Messiah would perform. This indicates that the religious atmosphere in Jesus' time was charged with apocalyptic expectation and a search for radical holiness.

- **Zealots:**

They were radical political activists who sought liberation from Roman rule, even by violent means if necessary. They emerged from the revolt of Judas the Galilean during the census of A.D. 6 and maintained anti-Roman resistance.

One of Jesus' apostles, Simon the Zealot (Luke 6:15), likely came from this movement. Although Jesus preached love for enemies and did not lead an armed rebellion, the existence of the Zealots reveals the intense patriotic fervor of the time. Rome was viewed

as an oppressive power, and the most zealous defenders of the Law believed sovereignty belonged only to God, not to Caesar. This tension culminated in the war of A.D. 66–70, in which the Zealots played a major role.

- **Herodians:**

Supporters of the Herodian dynasty (especially Herod Antipas), they were interested in maintaining the status quo under the Herodian tetrarchs, who were vassals of Rome. The Gospels mention them occasionally allying with the Pharisees against Jesus (Mark 3:6), perhaps fearing that His influence could destabilize the region politically. They were few in number and primarily a court-aligned political faction.

- **Samaritans:**

Not properly a Jewish sect, but the population of Samaria with its own religious tradition—a version of Israelite worship that accepted only the Pentateuch and worshiped on Mount Gerizim rather than in Jerusalem.

There was longstanding hostility between Jews and Samaritans, forming the background to Jesus’ dialogue with the Samaritan woman (John 4) and the parable of the Good Samaritan. In Jesus’ time, Samaritans lived alongside but somewhat separate from the Jewish population. Some Jewish pilgrims avoided passing through Samaria on their way to Jerusalem, yet Jesus traveled and preached there without prejudice (John 4; Luke 9:52–56). This demonstrates the internal ethnic and religious fractures within the land where Jesus carried out His ministry.

This mosaic of groups reveals a vibrant yet divided Jewish society. The common people generally respected Pharisees and scribes as religious authorities distrusted the aristocratic Sadducees, detested tax collectors (publicans) for collaborating with Rome, and longed for the coming of the Messiah who would bring liberation.

“He was Jewish and lived in a time of Messianic and apocalyptic expectations,” historians remind us. Many expected God to intervene soon to save Israel. Some envisioned a Davidic leader who would free them (a political vision), others a perfect high priest who would purify religion, others a prophet like Moses, or the mysterious “Son of Man” foretold in Daniel.

The Gospels reflect this expectation. For example, when Jesus is born, figures such as Simeon in the Temple are described as “waiting for the consolation of Israel” (Luke 2:25), and the prophetess Anna speaks of the child to “all who were looking for redemption” (Luke 2:38).

3.3 Historical Mentions of Jesus and External Context

Although the primary source for Jesus’ life is the Gospels and other New Testament writings, valuable extrabiblical references confirm certain details.

The Jewish historian Flavius Josephus (A.D. 37–100), in his *Antiquities of the Jews* written around A.D. 93, mentions Jesus in two passages. In the longer one (known as the *Testimonium Flavianum*), Josephus describes Him—though possibly with later Christian interpolations—as “a wise man... who performed surprising deeds... Pilate condemned Him to the cross... and it was said that He appeared alive again on the third day.”

Although the exact wording is debated, most scholars agree that Josephus did include a reference to Jesus, likely in a neutral tone, acknowledging His execution under Pilate and the existence of His followers. In another passage, Josephus recounts the death of “James, the brother of Jesus who is called the Christ” around A.D. 62—a text whose authenticity is widely accepted.

This demonstrates that by the late first century, non-Christian writers already took Jesus’ historical existence for granted and were aware of His reputation as the Christ (Messiah), even if they did not personally follow Him.

Josephus also describes in detail the execution of John the Baptist by Herod Antipas, portraying John as a good man who exhorted virtue and whose growing influence alarmed Herod. The Gospels confirm that Herod Antipas had John beheaded (Mark 6:17–28), though they attribute the immediate cause to Herodias’ intrigue. Josephus’ version—political fear of rebellion—complements the picture and shows how a prophet like John could be viewed as a public threat.

The Roman historian Cornelius Tacitus, in his *Annals* (c. A.D. 116), while describing the Great Fire of Rome under Nero (A.D. 64), mentions Christians as scapegoats and writes: “Christus, from whom the name had its origin, suffered the extreme penalty during the reign of Tiberius at the hands of... Pontius Pilate.”

This independent reference—considered authentic and historically significant—confirms basic facts: Jesus (Christus) was executed by order of Pilate during the reign of Emperor Tiberius (A.D. 14–37). Tacitus even notes that the “pernicious superstition” (Christianity) resurfaced after the temporary suppression caused by the death of its leader, first in Judea and then in Rome.

Another Roman writer, Suetonius, in a note about Emperor Claudius (A.D. 41–54), mentions that he expelled Jews from Rome who were “instigated by Chrestus,” often interpreted as a confused reference to disturbances among Jews over Christ (Christus) in the 40s—indicating that Christ’s figure was already causing agitation beyond Palestine within a few years of His death.

Additionally, Pliny the Younger, governor in Asia Minor, in a letter to Emperor Trajan (around A.D. 110), describes Christians who “sing hymns to Christ as to a god,” providing evidence of the early worship of Jesus.

These non-Christian testimonies, though brief, externally confirm Jesus’ historical existence and certain basic facts (His execution and the early spread of His followers). No

serious historian today doubts that Jesus of Nazareth was a real person in first-century Palestine—even critics such as Tacitus bear witness to it.

Of course, Jesus' figure transcends secular records: His impact was primarily religious and social, not political or military, so Roman chronicles mention Him only in passing in connection with Christians. Paradoxically, His political “insignificance” (from the Roman point of view) contrasts with the immense spiritual and cultural significance He would ultimately have.

3.4 Daily Life in the Time of Jesus

Beyond high politics and religious leadership, what was everyday life like in those times?

Yeshua was born into a humble Jewish family in the village of Nazareth in Galilee. Nazareth was such a small settlement that it is not mentioned in the Old Testament or in other contemporary sources, which once led some to question its existence. However, archaeologists have uncovered remains of first-century Nazareth: modest stone houses, caves used for storage, and water cisterns. In 2009, the first residential house from that period was discovered, with two rooms and a courtyard, confirming the image of Nazareth as a small rural village (perhaps only a few hundred inhabitants).

Vessels and chalkstone containers were found, indicating Jewish purity practices (chalkstone was used because, according to ritual law, it did not contract permanent impurity). Everything suggests a poor, agrarian population; “there are no jewels or luxuries,” one archaeologist reported, but simple utensils belonging to a modest family. This aligns with Nathanael's remark in the Gospel: “Can anything good come out of Nazareth?” (John 1:46), possibly reflecting a prejudice held by more sophisticated Galileans—or Judeans—toward that insignificant village.

Galilee in general was fertile, with agriculture and fishing centered around the Sea of Tiberias (Sea of Galilee). Jesus likely grew up working as a *tekton* (carpenter or craftsman) alongside Joseph, a term that could include construction work in wood and possibly stone or metal. He clearly belonged to the working class.

In Galilee, traditional Jewish culture coexisted with some Hellenistic influence: near Nazareth was Sepphoris, a city undergoing Hellenization, and later Herod Antipas founded Tiberias. Yet villages like Nazareth remained deeply Jewish in customs. Galilean Jews were sometimes viewed as less refined in religious observance than those in Judea, perhaps due to their interaction with Gentiles (Galilee bordered Gentile regions and had major trade routes near places like Capernaum). Nevertheless, Galilee produced several religious movements, including that of Judas the Galilean, and was marked by its own fervor.

Synagogues were integral to local life, functioning as schools and gathering places where the Torah was read every Sabbath. Jesus, though not known to have formal rabbinic training, astonished His fellow townspeople in Nazareth by teaching in the synagogue (Luke 4:16–22). This indicates that He knew how to read the Scriptures, likely having received basic instruction in the Law from a young age, as was customary for Jewish boys.

The Temple in Jerusalem was the national spiritual center. Jewish families sought to make pilgrimage there for major feasts such as Passover, Pentecost, or Tabernacles at least occasionally. Joseph and Mary traveled to Jerusalem every year for Passover (Luke 2:41), despite the considerable distance (about 140 km from Nazareth). This reflects both their piety and the relative safety of traveling in caravans during the Pax Romana.

In Jerusalem, Herod had expanded the Temple on a monumental scale; it was a source of national pride. A first-century inscription discovered archaeologically warns Gentiles not to pass beyond a certain point under penalty of death, illustrating the tension between Jewish ritual purity and pagan presence even there. While Jews under Roman rule enjoyed a degree of religious freedom (Rome allowed their exclusive worship of Jehovah), Roman procurators appointed high priests and controlled the sacred vestments of the high priest to maintain leverage over the clergy. At the time of Jesus' birth, the high priest likely belonged to the Sadducean faction aligned with Rome.

The regional economy was based on agriculture (wheat, barley, vineyards, olives), fishing, and artisan trades. Multiple layers of taxation burdened the people: taxes to Caesar, tolls on roads, religious tithes, and more. There was a stark contrast between the wealthy (a small landowning elite, often Sadducean) and poor peasants.

Jesus was born in a borrowed stable, and His family offered in the Temple the sacrifice of the poor (a pair of turtledoves, Luke 2:24). This economic reality is fundamental to His context. In His first programmatic sermon in Nazareth, He quoted: "The Lord has anointed Me... to preach good news to the poor" (Luke 4:18; Isaiah 61).

Regarding language, Jesus and His Jewish contemporaries primarily spoke Aramaic in daily life (the common Semitic language of Palestine since the exile). They also knew some Hebrew, especially for Scripture and synagogue liturgy. When Jesus read from Isaiah in the synagogue, He likely read in Hebrew and then explained in Aramaic.

Additionally, since Galilee was multiethnic and under Roman influence, many people understood sufficient Koine Greek for commerce and dealings with authorities. Jesus may have conversed in Greek with the Roman centurion or with Pilate (though this is not specified; Pilate may have used an interpreter). It is possible that Jesus functionally knew three languages. Most scholars agree that His teaching was primarily delivered in Aramaic and later translated into Greek in the Gospels.

3.5 Messianic Expectation

Reiterating a crucial point: first-century Jews were longing for liberation. As historians summarize, He "lived in a time of Messianic and apocalyptic expectations."

Various Messianic claimants arose before and after Jesus, generally with political aims (Acts 5:36–37 mentions Theudas and Judas the Galilean). The concept of "Messiah" (*Mashiach*) varied—some expected a Davidic warrior who would defeat the Romans;

others a purifying high priest; others a final prophet; still others the heavenly “Son of Man” described in Daniel 7:13. The Qumran Scrolls even speak of two Messiahs (one priestly and one royal).

When Jesus was born, the Gospels portray different reactions. Pagan magi perceived a cosmic sign (the star) and interpreted it as the birth of the King of the Jews. Herod the Great, suspicious and threatened, ordered the massacre of the children in Bethlehem (Matthew 2:1–16), a narrative consistent with his historically documented cruelty—Josephus records that Herod executed even three of his own sons out of suspicion. Although Josephus does not mention the massacre of the innocents, Matthew’s account is plausible given Herod’s ruthless character.

In Jerusalem, Luke presents Simeon and Anna recognizing in the infant Jesus the Messiah of Jehovah (Luke 2:25–38). Simeon proclaims the child as “a light for revelation to the Gentiles and glory for Your people Israel” (Luke 2:32), echoing Isaiah 49:6. Pious Jews saw the Messiah not only as Israel’s consolation but also as a light to all nations. This universal vision was not shared by all (some Zealots desired exclusion of Gentiles), but it was already present in Scripture and in movements such as Qumran.

In summary, Yeshua was born into a complex context: politically oppressed yet culturally diverse; religiously devout yet fractured into factions; socially humble yet positioned within a world increasingly interconnected by empire.

This context, in a sense, “prepared” the stage for His message. Roman peace and a common language facilitated the future spread of the Gospel; spiritual and social dissatisfaction created hearts longing for salvation. In biblical terms, “the harvest was ready.”

Amid all this, Jesus emerged as a figure who did not fit neatly into any faction—He was neither Pharisee, nor Sadducee, nor Zealot, nor Essene—yet embodied elements each group sought. He taught the Law with moral authority deeper than the Pharisees; He lived in poverty and purity reminiscent of Essene asceticism; He displayed zeal for true worship that even Zealots might respect; and He preached resurrection and the Kingdom of God, offering hope to ordinary people.

Historians note that two events in His life enjoy “almost universal certainty”: His baptism by John and His crucifixion under Pilate. These anchor Jesus firmly in the historical context described above: He was one among the crowds who followed John, and He ended as a victim of the Roman repressive system. And yet the interpretation of those events—and what followed—changed the world.

Chapter 3 Summary

- We have painted the historical and cultural background in which Yeshua's birth took place. Judea and Galilee were under Roman control, directly or indirectly, bringing oppression but also conditions that would later facilitate the spread of the message.
- We described the principal Jewish sects (Pharisees, Sadducees, Essenes, Zealots, and others) and their influence on society, recognizing that Jesus interacted with all of them in various ways. We mentioned historical evidence (Josephus, Tacitus) that anchors the Gospels in verifiable reality. We also explored daily life: the village of Nazareth and its archaeological confirmation, the centrality of language and religion in Jewish households, pilgrimages to the Temple, and the fervent hope for deliverance.
- All of this prepares us to enter the narrative of Yeshua's birth and childhood with a deeper understanding of His world. As we read of angels announcing, a virgin conceiving, shepherds marveling, and elderly prophets rejoicing, we can situate these scenes within the real first-century Palestine—a world filled with hardship and hope where, according to believers, “the Word became flesh and dwelt among us.”



Chapter 4: The Annunciations – Mary, Joseph, and the Dawn of Redemption

The coming of Yeshua the Messiah into the world was preceded by a series of extraordinary divine announcements. God prepared the stage by communicating His plan to specific individuals through heavenly messengers (angels) and revelations. In this chapter we will walk through the well-known Annunciations recorded in the Gospels of Luke and Matthew: the announcement of the birth of John the Baptist to his father Zechariah, the announcement of the birth of Jesus to the virgin Mary, and the revelation in a dream to Joseph about the divine identity of the child Mary was carrying.

We will also examine Mary's Magnificat and the inspired prophecies of devout people such as Zechariah and Elizabeth, revealing an atmosphere of joy and Messianic expectation. These episodes combine the supernatural (angels appearing, visions) with a strong rooting in ancient biblical promises, showing the continuity of God's plan. In addition, we will consider how different Christian traditions interpret Mary's role in these events and the theology of the Incarnation.

4.1 Announcement of the Forerunner: The Angel Gabriel to Zechariah — “I Will Prepare the Way Before You”

Before Yeshua was born, God announced the birth of His forerunner, John (Yochanan) the Baptist. According to Luke 1:5–25, the priest Zechariah, advanced in age, was serving in the Temple in Jerusalem—an honor that likely fell to him only once in his lifetime—when the angel Gabriel appeared to him beside the altar of incense.

Gabriel announced that his wife Elisheva (Elizabeth), barren and elderly, would conceive a son who “will be great before God... will go before the Lord in the spirit and power of Elijah, to prepare a people made ready” (Luke 1:15–17). This message clearly echoes the prophecy of Malachi 4:5–6 about Elijah's coming before the Day of the Lord.

Zechariah, astonished, doubted because of his age, and so the angel gave him a sign: he would be unable to speak until the word was fulfilled. And so, it happened—Zechariah came out of the sanctuary unable to speak to the amazement of the people waiting outside. This silence became symbolic: God was acting in such a wondrous way that human speech itself was overwhelmed.

When Elizabeth indeed became pregnant, she exclaimed: “Thus the Lord has done for me... to take away my reproach among people” (Luke 1:25), acknowledging God's mercy in granting her a child. At John's birth, Zechariah regained his speech and uttered a prophecy (the *Benedictus*): “Blessed be the Lord... He has raised up a horn of salvation in the house of David... And you, child, will be called the prophet of the Highest; for you will go before

the Lord to prepare His ways” (Luke 1:68–79). This hymn weaves together Davidic promises, the covenant with Abraham, and John’s preparatory mission.

Here we see how Luke presents the events in parallel: first the miraculous birth of John is announced to an infertile couple (recalling Old Testament stories such as Sarah or Hannah, the mother of Samuel) and then comes the greater announcement to Mary. The two births are linked; Luke tells us that Elizabeth and Mary were relatives (Luke 1:36) and were pregnant at the same time, with a six-month difference.

In Messianic Jewish tradition, John is seen clearly as the “Elijah” who was to come—his appearance closes the era of the ancient prophets and initiates the Messianic times.

4.2 The Annunciation to Mary — “Behold, You Will Conceive in Your Womb...”

The central moment of these announcements is the visitation of the angel Gabriel to Miriam (Mary), a young virgin from Nazareth, betrothed to Joseph. This episode (Luke 1:26–38) is known simply as “the Annunciation.”

Gabriel greets her: “Greetings, favored one! The Lord is with you; blessed are you among women.” Mary was troubled by such a greeting. Then the angel revealed to her:

“Do not be afraid, Mary, for you have found favor with God. And behold, you will conceive in your womb and bear a son, and you shall call His name Yeshua. He will be great and will be called the Son of the Most High; and the Lord God will give Him the throne of His father David; and He will reign over the house of Jacob forever, and of His kingdom there will be no end” (Luke 1:30–33).

This proclamation is dense with Messianic content: it alludes to the Davidic promise of an eternal reign (2 Samuel 7:12–13; Isaiah 9:7) and to the Messiah’s divine sonship. Mary, not doubting God but puzzled about how it would occur, asks: “How will this be, since I do not know a man?” (Luke 1:34). Gabriel explains:

“The Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you; therefore, the One who will be born will be called holy—the Son of God” (Luke 1:35).

Thus, he announces the virginal Incarnation: Mary will conceive miraculously by the work of the Holy Spirit, without the involvement of a man. He also gives a confirming sign: her relative Elizabeth has also conceived in her old age “for nothing will be impossible with God” (Luke 1:36–37).

Mary’s response marked history: “Behold, I am the servant of the Lord; let it be to me according to your word” (Luke 1:38). With this humble and courageous acceptance, Mary became a participant in the divine plan.

In Catholic and Orthodox theology, this moment is crucial: Mary's *fiat*, her "yes" that receives salvation. She is called the New Eve who, unlike the first, obeys God unconditionally, becoming the Mother of all believers in a spiritual sense.

Mary's importance is strongly emphasized in these traditions. Catholics and Orthodox celebrate the Annunciation (March 25) as a solemn feast, considering that moment to be the Incarnation itself—the Word becoming flesh in Mary's womb. In Catholic teaching, Mary was preserved from original sin from her own conception (the dogma of the Immaculate Conception, connected to the greeting "full of grace"), and she remained a virgin before, during, and after childbirth (the dogma of perpetual virginity). The Orthodox Church likewise calls her *Aeiparthenos* (ever-virgin) and *Theotokos* (Mother of God), emphasizing that the child she carried was truly God made man.

These theological formulations emerged centuries later, but they have roots in the high Christology Luke already presents: the child is "Son of the Most High," "Son of God" from the beginning.

Protestant Christians share belief in the virgin birth and honor Mary as an example of faith and obedience, but they do not accept later dogmas such as the Immaculate Conception or Mary's special intercessory role, aiming to keep the focus on Christ.

Messianic Jewish communities honor Mary as Miriam, the faithful young Jewish woman who gave birth to Israel's Messiah, but without attributing to her superhuman qualities. They emphasize her Jewish context (for example, that she fulfilled post-partum purification rites, Luke 2:22–24, demonstrating her piety according to the Law).

4.3 The Meeting of the Mothers: The Visitation

Immediately after the Annunciation, according to Luke 1:39–56, Mary hurried to the hill country of Judea to visit her relative Elizabeth, who was six months pregnant. When she arrived and greeted her, something profoundly spiritual occurred: the baby (John) leaped in Elizabeth's womb, and she was filled with the Holy Spirit, exclaiming in a loud voice:

"Blessed are you among women and blessed is the fruit of your womb! And why is this granted to me, that the mother of my Lord should come to me?" (Luke 1:42–43).

These words confirm that Elizabeth, inspired by the Spirit, recognized Mary not merely as a cousin but as the Mother of the Lord. She calls the unborn Jesus "my Lord," demonstrating Messianic awareness even before His birth. John's leap for joy signifies that even before being born, he was already beginning his mission of pointing to the presence of Christ.

Elizabeth also honors Mary's faith: "Blessed is she who believed, for there will be a fulfillment of what was spoken to her from the Lord" (Luke 1:45).

In response, Mary offers a hymn of praise known in tradition as the *Magnificat* (from its first word in Latin): "My soul magnifies the Lord, and my spirit rejoices in God my Savior..." (Luke 1:46–55).

This song is woven with Old Testament references. It recalls Hannah’s song in 1 Samuel 2 (another mother who received a child by divine grace), proclaims God’s faithfulness to the promises made to Abraham, and anticipates the spiritual reversal brought by the Messiah:

“He has brought down the mighty from their thrones and exalted the humble; He has filled the hungry with good things, and the rich He has sent away empty.”

Thus, the *Magnificat* presents God as the One who overturns human fortunes—a theme Yeshua Himself would repeat (for example, in the Beatitudes). This canticle is prayed or sung daily in the Catholic liturgy of Vespers, underscoring its doctrinal importance: it reveals Mary as a model of humility and as a prophetess announcing God’s saving justice.

Mary remained with Elizabeth for about three months, likely until John’s birth. One can imagine those weeks of holy companionship: two miraculously pregnant women sharing faith and hope, reflecting on the Scriptures together. Traditionally, it is thought that Luke may have obtained details of Jesus’ infancy from Mary herself (or from those close to her), which would explain the vivid and intimate nature of these accounts.

4.4 The Revelation to Joseph in a Dream

The Gospel according to Matthew complements the story from the perspective of Yosef (Joseph), Mary’s husband. In Matthew 1:18–25 we read that, before the marriage was consummated, Joseph discovered that Mary was pregnant “through the Holy Spirit.”

Although Mary likely explained what had happened, Joseph faced a serious dilemma. As a righteous man, he did not wish to disgrace her publicly, yet he considered divorcing her quietly to spare her shame—or worse (the Law prescribed severe penalties for pregnancy outside marriage).

While Joseph was considering this, “an angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream” and said:

“Joseph, son of David, do not fear to take Mary as your wife, for what is conceived in her is from the Holy Spirit. She will bear a son, and you shall call His name Yeshua, for He will save His people from their sins” (Matthew 1:20–21).

This message confirms what was told to Mary but adds Joseph’s perspective. It emphasizes his title “son of David,” encouraging him to legally acknowledge Jesus as his son and thereby insert Him into the Davidic line. It also reveals the meaning of the name Yeshua (Jesus): “YHWH saves.” Indeed, *Yehoshua* means “Jehovah is salvation,” and the angel declares that this child will save from sins—pointing to a mission more spiritual than political.

Matthew adds that all this fulfilled Isaiah 7:14: “The virgin shall conceive... and they shall call His name Immanuel,” meaning “God with us” (Matthew 1:22–23), applying it fully to Jesus.

Upon waking, Joseph did as the angel commanded: he took Mary as his wife, protected her, and “knew her not” (did not have marital relations) “until she had given birth to her firstborn son; and he called His name Yeshua” (Matthew 1:25).

Joseph thus appears as another model of faithful obedience. He accepts God’s will without recorded speech—indeed, the Gospels do not preserve a single word spoken by Joseph; his actions speak for him. Christian tradition has honored him as “the righteous one,” and in Catholic devotion he is patron of the universal Church. Protestants and Messianic believers likewise see him as an example of integrity and quiet faith.

Some denominations debate the meaning of the phrase “until she had given birth.” Catholics and Orthodox maintain that this does not imply that Joseph later “knew” Mary; they uphold her perpetual virginity and interpret the “brothers of Jesus” as close relatives or, according to some traditions, children from a previous marriage of Joseph. Protestants generally interpret that Joseph and Mary’s marriage was fully consummated after Jesus’ birth and that they had other children, citing passages such as Mark 6:3, where brothers (James, Joses, Simon, Judas) and sisters of Jesus are mentioned.

This divergence does not affect the core of the narrative: all agree on Mary’s virginity at the conception of Jesus and on Joseph’s role as legal father, guardian, and obedient servant of God.

4.5 Historical and Theological Perspective

The Annunciations contain supernatural elements that are difficult for secular historiography—angelic appearances, virginal conception—yet they carry profound theological weight. From the perspective of faith, they form the foundation of the Incarnation: God entering history in a miraculous way, yet without violating human freedom (Mary freely consents).

It is noteworthy that Luke claims to have investigated everything carefully (Luke 1:3). His inclusion of these details suggests that first-generation Christians considered these accounts credible and essential. They do not resemble Hellenistic myths later inserted into the narrative, as sometimes alleged, because the details are deeply rooted in Jewish biblical tradition: the angel Gabriel, barren women conceiving, hymns to Jehovah, the Messiah on David’s throne, and so forth.

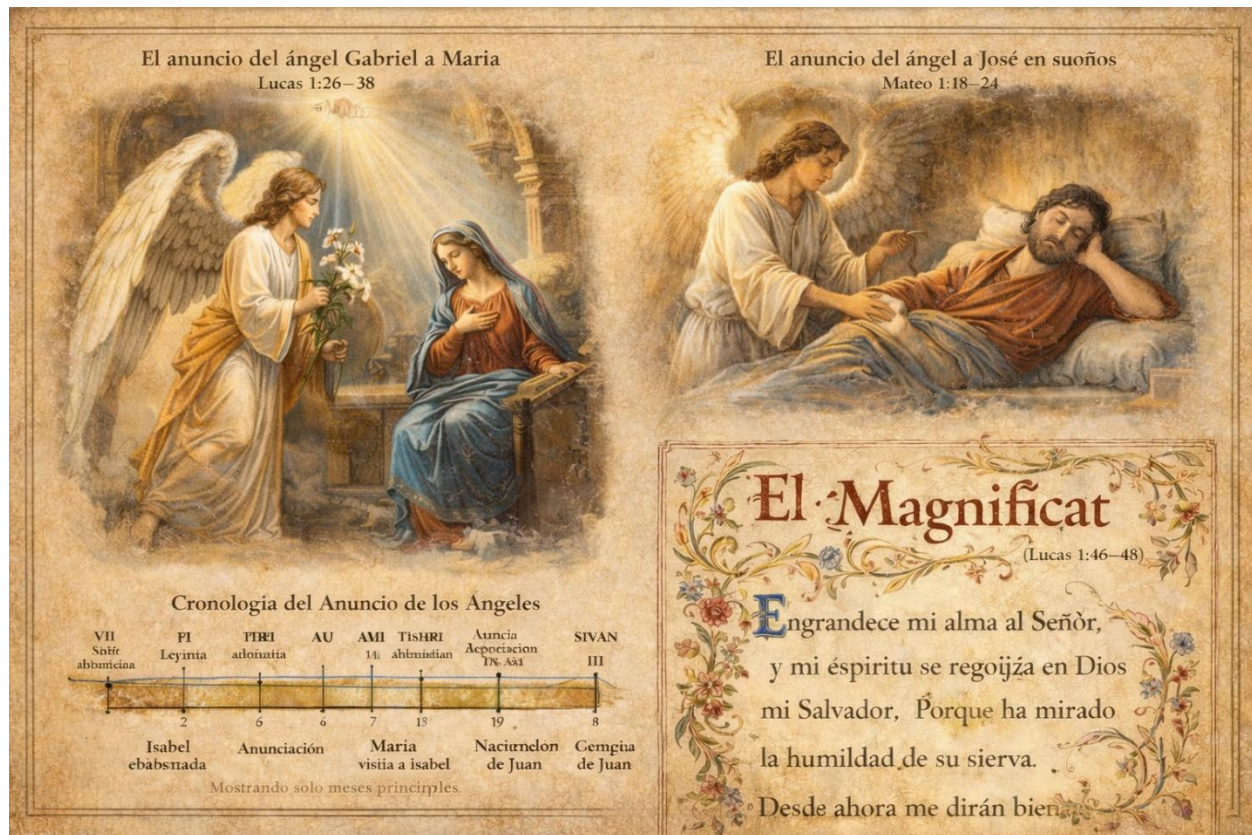
Indeed, Luke’s theology in these chapters constantly connects with the Old Testament. Luke 1–2 cites or alludes to Genesis, Samuel, Psalms, Isaiah, Malachi, and more than almost any other New Testament section, showing that early Christians saw in Jesus the fulfillment of Israel’s entire previous history.

From a historical standpoint, the events of the Annunciations would have been known by very few (Mary, Joseph, Elizabeth, Zechariah). It is plausible that Mary herself was the source of this information within the early Christian community. Luke twice mentions that

“Mary treasured up all these things, pondering them in her heart” (Luke 2:19, 51), suggesting that she carefully remembered the extraordinary experiences surrounding the birth of her son.

Chapter 4 Summary

- God announced the imminent arrival of the Messiah in a manner both astonishing and intimate: by sending the angel Gabriel to humble and devout individuals. Zechariah received the news of the birth of John the Baptist, who would prepare the way of the Lord. Mary received the most sublime announcement: she would conceive by the Holy Spirit the Son of the Most High, fulfilling the Messianic promises. Elizabeth, filled with the Spirit, confirmed Mary’s blessing as the Mother of the Lord, and Mary sang the *Magnificat*, proclaiming God’s faithfulness to His covenant. Joseph, a righteous man, accepted through a divine dream his role as the legal father of Jesus, thus safeguarding the Davidic lineage and giving the Savior His name.
- In these annunciations we see the convergence of simple faith (Mary: “let it be to me according to your word”), prophetic joy (Elizabeth: “blessed are you among women”), and obedience in action (Joseph took Mary as his wife).
- Theologically, the central truth of the Incarnation is affirmed here: Jesus is truly God with us (Immanuel) and truly human, born of a woman. The various Christian traditions venerate this moment in distinctive ways: Catholic and Orthodox traditions emphasize Mary’s purity and holiness as *Theotokos*; Protestant traditions admire her example of faith and place the emphasis on Christ who becomes incarnate; Messianic communities see the fulfillment of Israel’s prophecies and God’s faithfulness to His people.
- With the announcements fulfilled, the stage is now set for the birth of Yeshua in Bethlehem, which we will address in the next chapter.



Chapter 5: The Nativity – Jesus’s Birth in Bethlehem

We now arrive at the birth of Yeshua—the event in which “the Word became flesh” (John 1:14) and came to dwell among us. This chapter recounts the well-known narrative of Christmas, integrating the accounts of the Gospels of Luke and Matthew, which provide complementary perspectives: Luke focuses on Mary’s experience and the shepherds in Bethlehem, while Matthew recounts the visit of the Magi from the East and the subsequent actions of King Herod.

We will examine each aspect: the journey of Joseph and Mary to Bethlehem because of the census; the humble birth in a manger; the angelic announcement to the shepherds and their adoration of the newborn; then the arrival of the wise men guided by a star, the Messianic gifts they present, and Herod’s dark reaction—the massacre of the innocents and the family’s flight into Egypt.

We will also analyze the fulfillment of several prophecies in these events and the theological significance the Church has discerned in each sign (for example, Jesus being born in poverty, the symbolism of the star, and so forth). Brief mention will also be made of

extrabiblical traditions and historical developments surrounding the celebration of Christmas.

5.1 The Census and the Journey to Bethlehem

The Gospel of Luke places Jesus' birth within a concrete historical framework:

"In those days a decree went out from Caesar Augustus that all the world should be registered... And Joseph went up from Galilee, from the city of Nazareth to Judea, to the city of David called Bethlehem, because he was of the house and lineage of David, to be registered with Mary, his betrothed, who was with child" (Luke 2:1–5).

Caesar Augustus, the Roman emperor, ordered a census (likely for taxation purposes). Luke states that this was the "first census when Quirinius was governing Syria," an identification that has generated chronological debate, since the well-known census of Quirinius occurred in A.D. 6, while Jesus was born before 4 B.C.

Various explanations have been proposed: perhaps a local registration preceded the full Roman census; perhaps Quirinius exercised earlier authority in the region; or Luke may be using a broader administrative reference. In any case, Luke's theological point is clear: God used even imperial decrees to accomplish His plan—bringing Joseph and Mary to Bethlehem precisely when the child was to be born, thus fulfilling Micah 5:2 regarding the Messiah's birth in Bethlehem.

Bethlehem, a small village near Jerusalem, was called the "city of David" because King David had been born and anointed there (1 Samuel 16). For a biblically informed reader, the mere fact that Jesus was born in Bethlehem evokes Davidic lineage and Messianic legitimacy. Since Joseph belonged to David's family, he had to register there; tradition suggests he may have had relatives in Bethlehem.

Arriving in Bethlehem, "while they were there, the time came for her to give birth" (Luke 2:6). Luke narrates simply yet movingly:

"She gave birth to her firstborn son and wrapped Him in swaddling clothes and laid Him in a manger, because there was no room for them in the inn" (Luke 2:7).

The image of the manger a feeding trough for animals—signals the humility and poverty of the circumstances. Likely, because many travelers had arrived due to the census, the guest room or lodging place in Bethlehem was full. Joseph and Mary found shelter in a stable or cave used for livestock. There Yeshua was born.

This scene of God being born in the most modest conditions has been contemplated by generations of Christians as a sign of the *kenosis* (self-emptying) of the Son of God: The King of the universe is not born in a palace but among animals; His first bed is not a luxurious cradle but a manger. This is often seen as foreshadowing Jesus' life of simplicity and total self-giving, as well as His solidarity with the poor.

In Christian art, the manger scene—with Mary, Joseph, the child, and sometimes an ox and a donkey (symbolically inspired by Isaiah 1:3)—is ubiquitous. Catholic and Orthodox devotion has richly developed the tenderness of this moment: the Virgin Mary is called Mother of God because she gives birth to Jesus, who is God made child; Saint Joseph is seen caring for the Redeemer in His vulnerability; the Holy Family is presented as a model of faith and love.

Protestants likewise celebrate this radical humility of Christ, focusing on its theological meaning: here, in the Incarnation, God begins the redemption of the world, identifying not with the powerful but with the lowly.

5.2 The Shepherds and the Angelic Chorus

The first to receive the news of the birth were shepherds in the hills near Bethlehem. “And there were shepherds in the same region, keeping watch over their flock by night” (Luke 2:8). An angel of the Lord appeared to them, and the glory of God shone around them, filling them with fear.

The angel proclaimed:

“Do not be afraid, for behold, I bring you good news of great joy that will be for all the people: for unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord. And this will be a sign for you: you will find a baby wrapped in swaddling clothes and lying in a manger” (Luke 2:10–12).

Suddenly, a “multitude of the heavenly host” appeared with the angel, praising God and saying:

“Glory to God in the highest, and on earth peace, goodwill toward men!” (Luke 2:13–14).

This extraordinary scene presents the angels—heavenly messengers—as the first evangelists, announcing the Gospel (good news) of the Savior’s birth. Their words confirm Jesus’ identity: He is Savior (bringing liberation—not political, but from sin, as the angel told Joseph), He is Christ (the Anointed Messiah), and He is Lord (a title of divine authority).

The proclamation of “peace on earth” summarizes the Messianic purpose: to bring peace between God and humanity (reconciliation) and among human beings themselves.

It is significant that shepherds were chosen to receive the announcement first. Socially, shepherds were simple people, sometimes viewed as rough or even ritually unclean due to their outdoor occupation. Yet in Luke’s theology, the poor and marginalized are privileged recipients of grace—a theme anticipated in the *Magnificat*: “He has exalted the humble.” Once again, God reveals Himself to the lowly before the wise or powerful.

After hearing the message, the shepherds said to one another, “Let us go now to Bethlehem and see this thing that has happened” (Luke 2:15). They went with haste and found Mary and Joseph, and the baby lying in a manger, just as they had been told. They recounted what the angel had said concerning the child, and Luke notes that “all who

heard it wondered.” He adds: “But Mary treasured up all these things, pondering them in her heart” (Luke 2:18–19).

The shepherds returned glorifying and praising God for all they had seen and heard (Luke 2:20). In this final detail, the shepherds themselves become messengers, spreading the good news in Bethlehem and astonishing those who heard them—perhaps Joseph’s relatives or neighbors nearby.

Mary reflects in silence, indicating that these events deepened her growing understanding of her son’s mystery. The shepherds’ adoration has traditionally been interpreted as the beginning of humble humanity’s worship of Christ.

In the Christmas Nativity scene—popularized in tangible form by Saint Francis of Assisi in 1223—the shepherds are always present, bringing simple offerings (a lamb, milk) to honor the newborn King. This contrasts with and prepares for the next scene in Matthew: the adoration of wealthy and learned figures, the Magi. Together, these two scenes—poor Jewish shepherds and wealthy Gentile sages—symbolize the universality of Jesus’ mission: He is recognized both by the lowliest of Israel and by representatives of the nations.

5.3 The Circumcision and Presentation in the Temple

(Though part of the subsequent infancy narrative, it is worth briefly including here.)

On the eighth day, Jesus was circumcised according to the Law of Moses (Luke 2:21), officially receiving the name Yeshua as the angel had instructed. This demonstrates that His parents faithfully observed the Torah. Jesus was incorporated into the Abrahamic covenant through circumcision—an important point emphasized by Messianic communities to show that He did not come to abolish the Law but to fulfill it.

Forty days after His birth, Mary and Joseph brought the child to Jerusalem to present Him to the Lord and for Mary to complete her post-partum purification, offering the sacrifice of the poor (a pair of turtle doves). There, the prophecies of Simeon and Anna took place, as mentioned earlier. Simeon declared the child to be “a light for revelation to the Gentiles,” but also told Mary: “a sword will pierce your own soul” (Luke 2:35), alluding to the future suffering of Christ—and of her.

After this, according to Luke 2:39, the family returned to Nazareth. Matthew, however, recounts that before settling permanently in Nazareth, the visit of the Magi and the flight to Egypt occurred. These accounts can be harmonized by assuming that the Temple visit was brief and that the family returned temporarily to Bethlehem before ultimately relocating to Nazareth.

5.4 The Visit of the Magi from the East

The Gospel of Matthew 2:1–12 relates:

“Now after Jesus was born in Bethlehem of Judea in the days of King Herod, behold, wise men from the East came to Jerusalem, saying, ‘Where is He who has been born King of the Jews? For we have seen His Star in the East and have come to worship Him.’”

These Magi were wise men, possibly astrologer-priests from Persia or Babylon, familiar with celestial movements and perhaps with Eastern prophecies concerning a great king in Judea. The Greek word *magoi* refers to learned men skilled in astrology or esoteric sciences—not stage magicians, but scholarly observers of the heavens.

They observed a special star and interpreted it as signaling the birth of a king in Judah. Various theories have been proposed about the Star of Bethlehem: a planetary conjunction (such as Jupiter and Saturn in 7 B.C.), a nova or supernova, or a comet. Matthew does not specify; the theological meaning is primary: God revealed the Messiah also to the Gentiles (represented by these pagan sages), possibly using their own symbolic language—the heavens—to guide them.

This fulfills prophecies such as:

- “The kings of Tarshish and of Sheba shall bring gifts” (Psalm 72:10),
- “Nations shall come to your light” (Isaiah 60:3, 6),
- and recalls Balaam’s prophecy of the “star out of Jacob” (Numbers 24:17).

Christian tradition sees in the Magi a prelude to the conversion of the nations.

The Magi first arrived in Jerusalem, seeking the newborn “King of the Jews.” Hearing this, “King Herod was troubled, and all Jerusalem with him” (Matthew 2:3). Herod gathered the chief priests and scribes to inquire where the Messiah was to be born. They replied: “In Bethlehem of Judea,” quoting Micah 5:2.

Herod then secretly summoned the Magi, determined the time of the star’s appearance (to estimate the child’s age), and sent them to Bethlehem, saying hypocritically, “When you have found Him, bring me word, that I too may come and worship Him.”

As they went, the star appeared again and “stood over the place where the child was” (Matthew 2:9), suggesting a providential sign rather than an ordinary astronomical phenomenon, since it appears to guide them directly. “When they saw the star, they rejoiced exceedingly with great joy” (2:10).

Entering the house (note: “house,” indicating that by this time the Holy Family was living in a dwelling in Bethlehem rather than the stable), they saw the child with Mary His mother, and “falling down, they worshiped Him; and opening their treasures, they offered Him gifts: gold, frankincense, and myrrh” (2:11).

These gifts have been symbolically interpreted:

- **Gold** for Christ's kingship (gold for a king),
- **Frankincense** for His divinity (incense offered to God),
- **Myrrh** (used in embalming) foreshadowing His suffering and redemptive death.

Thus, tradition sees in the Magi the First Gentiles to worship Jesus, recognizing Him with prophetic acts. The Church commemorates this in the feast of Epiphany (January 6 in the West), emphasizing Christ's manifestation to the nations.

In iconography, the Magi are often portrayed as kings of different races and ages (though Matthew does not call them kings nor specify their number; three was inferred from the three gifts). Warned in a dream not to return to Herod, they departed for their country by another route (2:12), frustrating the tyrant's plans.

5.5 The Flight to Egypt and the Massacre of the Innocents

When Herod realized that he had been deceived by the Magi, he reacted with his characteristic cruelty. "In great fury, he sent and killed all the male children in Bethlehem and in all that region who were two years old or under, according to the time he had determined from the Magi" (Matthew 2:16).

This tragic episode is known as the Massacre of the Innocents. Matthew sees in it the fulfillment of Jeremiah 31:15:

"A voice was heard in Ramah, weeping and great mourning: Rachel weeping for her children..."

(Matthew 2:18).

This poetic image—originally referring to Israel's sorrow in exile—is applied to the lament of the mothers of Bethlehem.

Historically, Josephus does not record this specific event, perhaps because he considered it minor compared to Herod's other atrocities. In a small village like Bethlehem, the number of male infants under two years old may have been only a few dozen.

Nevertheless, as previously noted, the episode fits perfectly with Herod's documented character: a ruler who executed even three of his own sons out of paranoid fear of losing his throne.

Emperor Augustus reportedly remarked sarcastically that it was better to be "Herod's pig than his son"—a dark joke implying that, since Herod followed Jewish customs and would not kill pigs, but had no hesitation in killing his own children, animals were safer than his heirs. In this light, the massacre in Bethlehem is entirely plausible within its historical context.

Before the slaughter could occur, however, an angel of the Lord warned Joseph in a dream:

“Rise, take the child and His mother, and flee to Egypt, and remain there until I tell you, for Herod is about to search for the child, to destroy Him” (Matthew 2:13).

Joseph obeyed immediately: “He rose and took the child and His mother by night and departed to Egypt” (2:14).

They likely remained there only a short time, since Matthew adds that after Herod’s death (which occurred in 4 B.C.), the angel informed Joseph that it was safe to return, thus fulfilling another prophetic word:

“Out of Egypt I called My Son” (Matthew 2:15), quoting Hosea 11:1 and applying it typologically to Jesus.

Just as Israel—the “son” of God—came out of Egypt in the Exodus, so Jesus, the true Son, recapitulates that history. The flight to Egypt not only preserves Jesus’ life but carries deep symbolic meaning. Egypt had traditionally been a place of refuge for those in need from Canaan: Abraham went down to Egypt during famine; Jacob and his sons settled there in Joseph’s time; and in later periods there were established Jewish communities in Egypt.

In His own person, Jesus relives Israel’s story: descending into Egypt and then, after the death of the persecutor, returning to the Promised Land—like a new Moses or the embodiment of a renewed Israel. In Matthew’s theology, Jesus fulfills Scripture not only through direct predictions but also through historical parallels and patterns.

After Herod’s death, his kingdom was divided (as discussed in Chapter 3): Judea came under Archelaus, a volatile and dangerous ruler. When Joseph returned, he was afraid to settle in Judea (where Bethlehem was located), because Archelaus reigned there. Warned again in a dream, he withdrew to Galilee, governed by Herod Antipas, who posed less immediate danger.

Thus, the family settled in Nazareth, their original town, fulfilling what “was spoken by the prophets, that He would be called a Nazarene” (Matthew 2:23).

This final citation is intriguing, as it does not correspond to a specific Old Testament verse. It may be a wordplay by Matthew linking “Nazareth” with *nezer* (“branch”) in Isaiah 11:1: “There shall come forth a shoot from the stump of Jesse, and a branch (*nezer*) shall grow out of his roots,” pointing to Jesus as the Davidic branch growing in “Nazareth”—the town of the Branch. Alternatively, it may echo Judges 13:5 regarding a *Nazirite* consecrated to God.

In any case, Matthew concludes his infancy narrative by emphasizing that even the seemingly incidental detail of Jesus’ hometown fits within the broader prophetic and divine design.

5.6 The Birth of Jesus: Theological and Historical Perspectives

From early times, the Church proclaimed in the Creed:

“For us and for our salvation He came down from heaven, and by the Holy Spirit was incarnate of the Virgin Mary and became man.”

This mystery of Christmas has been venerated by all Christian denominations, though the emphasis may vary.

The ancient Churches (Catholic and Orthodox) surrounded the Nativity with solemn liturgies, Marian theology, and devotional traditions (the manger scene, hymns, sacred art, and more). Protestant communities celebrate it with a focus on the Incarnation of the Word and the humility of Christ, generally with less emphasis on Marian doctrine. Messianic communities sometimes highlight parallels with Jewish feasts—for example, some suggest that Jesus may have been born during the Feast of Tabernacles (“He dwelt among us”), or that His conception occurred at Hanukkah and His birth at Sukkot.

Nevertheless, the traditional date of December 25 (in the West) and January 6 (Epiphany) is more symbolic than historically certain; it emerged centuries later in the Church’s liturgical development. Some argue that the shepherds “keeping watch by night” suggest a springtime birth; others propose different seasons. The precise date remains uncertain. What is essential is the meaning: the virginal birth of Christ marks the visible beginning of redemption.

It should also be noted that the Nativity account has been challenged by skeptical critics, who argue that it may be a theological myth rather than history. While the miraculous elements (angels, the star) cannot be verified by secular historiography, many historical components align with what we know: the reign of Herod, the Messianic atmosphere of the time, the king’s cruelty, Roman census practices, and the social reality of shepherds and foreign sages.

There is nothing inherently implausible in Jesus being born in Bethlehem even if His family was from Nazareth (they may have had relatives or ancestral property there). Christians maintain that the evangelists transmitted faithful testimony, not invented legends, supported by the prophetic coherence that frames the entire narrative.

Chapter 5 Summary

- Yeshua was born in Bethlehem of Judea, fulfilling prophecy, in simplicity and poverty—laid in a manger because there was no room for them in the inn. A chorus of angels announced His birth to humble shepherds, proclaiming peace and

salvation for the people. Those shepherds became the first human worshipers of Jesus, a foretaste of all the pure in heart who would receive Him.

- Eight days later, He was circumcised and given the name Jesus— “God saves”—signifying His mission. Later, wise men from the East, guided by an extraordinary star, came to pay Him homage with symbolic gifts—gold, frankincense, and myrrh—recognizing Him as King, God, and suffering Redeemer. Thus, Gentiles from afar joined nearby Jews in worshiping the Messiah, demonstrating the universal scope of His mission.
- Meanwhile, King Herod, feeling threatened, sought to kill Him, carrying out the massacre of the children of Bethlehem in a futile attempt to extinguish the rising light. But God protected His Son: Joseph, obeying angelic visions, took the family to Egypt until Herod’s death, and afterward established the child’s upbringing in Nazareth of Galilee, which would be His home for the next thirty years.
- All these events are interwoven with Scripture: “Out of Bethlehem shall come a Shepherd of Israel,” “Out of Egypt I called My Son,” “In Ramah was heard weeping,” “He shall be called a Nazarene”—demonstrating that from the beginning Yeshua’s life was guided by the redemptive plan of God revealed through the prophets.
- In this miraculous and humble birth, the Creator entered His creation as a vulnerable child, fulfilling the promises made to Abraham and David, and bringing “glory to God in the highest” and “peace on earth.”



Chapter 6: Childhood and Early Years in Nazareth

After the extraordinary events surrounding Yeshua's birth, the Gospels offer only brief glimpses of His childhood and youth. This chapter gathers the available information about Jesus' upbringing in Nazareth, His physical, intellectual, and spiritual development, as well as His family context (Mary, Joseph, and His relatives). It will also address the only episode from His youth recorded in the Gospels: Jesus at twelve years old in the Temple of Jerusalem, dialoguing with the teachers.

In addition, we will consider historical and apocryphal traditions about Jesus' childhood—some drawn from non-canonical texts such as the *Protoevangelium of James* and the *Infancy Gospel of Thomas*—not because they carry authority, but because of their influence on art and culture, and to contrast them with the sober biblical narrative. We will also analyze how different theological traditions understand this “hidden” period of Christ's life: His submission to His parents, His growth in wisdom, and His full human experience.

6.1 Nazareth: Home of the Holy Family

After returning from Egypt following Herod's death, Joseph and Mary settled permanently in Nazareth, in Galilee (Matthew 2:23; Luke 2:39). Nazareth thus became the town where Jesus spent nearly all His life until about the age of thirty.

As described in earlier chapters, Nazareth was a small agricultural village nestled in the hills of Galilee, with perhaps only a few hundred inhabitants. It was not a renowned place; recall Nathanael's remark: “Can anything good come out of Nazareth?” (John 1:46), reflecting its perceived insignificance.

Yet the fact that God chose for His Son to grow up there aligns with the pattern of voluntary humility: Jesus did not grow up in great Jerusalem or amid luxury, but in a rural, simple setting, learning the manual trade of His adoptive father.

Joseph worked as a *tekton*, a Greek term traditionally translated “carpenter,” but more accurately meaning craftsman, builder, or artisan. Given the materials available in the region, he likely worked with both wood and stone. It is probable that from a young age Jesus assisted him and eventually practiced the trade Himself (in Mark 6:3, the people of Nazareth refer to Him as “the carpenter”).

This indicates that until approximately age thirty, Jesus lived an ordinary working life, experiencing the fatigue of labor and the daily responsibility of earning a living.

Theologically, this is deeply significant: it dignifies human work, demonstrating that the Son of God sanctified ordinary life and manual labor by participating fully in them.

The Family of Jesus

The Gospels mention Mary, His mother, on several occasions, and Joseph only in the infancy narratives (after Luke 2, Joseph no longer appears, suggesting that he likely died before Jesus' public ministry). In addition, the "brothers" of Jesus are mentioned: James, Joses (Joseph), Simon, Judas, and unnamed sisters (Mark 6:3; Matthew 13:55–56).

The interpretation of who these "brothers" are varies:

- The Catholic and Orthodox Churches maintain that Mary remained perpetually a virgin. Therefore, these *adelphoi* ("brothers") would actually be cousins (possibly sons of another Mary, wife of Clopas, as speculated), or even children of Joseph from a previous marriage. In Orthodox tradition, Joseph is sometimes portrayed as an older widower with children when he becomes betrothed to Mary. These traditions draw in part from texts such as the *Protoevangelium of James* (a second-century apocryphal work) that narrates Mary's early life and her virginal consecration.
- Most Protestant theologians, by contrast, interpret that after Jesus' birth, Joseph and Mary lived a normal married life and had additional children. These would be literal half-brothers and sisters of Jesus—for example, James, "the brother of the Lord," who later became a leader of the Jerusalem church.
- Messianic communities generally follow the Protestant reading, seeing Jesus as the eldest son within a larger Jewish family.

While interesting, this question does not alter the essential point: Jesus grew up in a loving and devout family environment, with Mary and Joseph as models of faith. Luke emphasizes that they "fulfilled all things according to the law of the Lord" (Luke 2:39). Thus, the child Jesus would have learned the Scriptures at home and in the synagogue, celebrated Jewish festivals with His family, and experienced both the solidarity and the tensions natural to family life.

6.2 Growth in Wisdom and Grace

Luke 2:40 offers a beautiful summary:

"The child grew and became strong, filled with wisdom; and the grace of God was upon Him."

Later, after the episode at age twelve, Luke adds:

"And Jesus increased in wisdom and in stature, and in favor with God and men" (Luke 2:52).

These statements underscore the true humanity of Jesus. Although He was the Son of God, He did not appear as an omniscient adult from the cradle. Rather, He followed the normal process of human development. He “was made like His brothers in every respect” (Hebrews 2:17), including the stages of childhood, adolescence, and young adulthood.

Christian theology affirms that in Jesus the divine and human natures coexist. During His childhood and youth, His human knowledge was genuine: He had to learn to speak, to read, to pray. Joseph likely taught Him the Torah and the daily prayers (such as the *Shema Yisrael*). He accompanied His parents to the synagogue each Sabbath and to Jerusalem for the feasts (Luke 2:41 notes that the family went yearly to Passover). He worked in Joseph’s workshop, sweated, ate, and rested.

All this refutes early heresies that denied Christ’s full humanity. The Church insists that Jesus “grew in wisdom”—a profound mystery, since as God He is omniscient, yet according to His human nature He acquired knowledge progressively.

Apocryphal infancy gospels from the second and third centuries sometimes depict a child Jesus performing whimsical miracles (such as giving life to clay birds or stretching a miscut plank in Joseph’s workshop). While popular in folklore, these stories are not regarded as historically reliable nor consistent with the biblical portrait. The canonical Gospels present a Jesus who performs no public signs until after His baptism by John; His first miracle—turning water into wine at Cana—occurs in adulthood.

It is therefore likely that in Nazareth Jesus lived a hidden and outwardly ordinary life, without conspicuous miraculous manifestations—so much so that His own neighbors later expressed astonishment: “Is this not the carpenter, the son of Mary...? How are such mighty works done by His hands?”

Nevertheless, “the grace of God was upon Him” indicates that even from childhood there was a distinctive holiness and wisdom in Jesus, perhaps perceived by those closest to Him. Catholic devotion speaks of the Sacred Heart of Jesus burning with divine love even in His youth, and the Orthodox celebrate the Feast of the Presentation (Meeting of the Lord) as the revelation of Christ the Child to Simeon.

6.3 Jesus at Twelve Years Old in the Temple

The only specific account of Jesus’ youth is found in Luke 2:41–51. When Jesus was twelve years old, He went with His parents to Jerusalem for Passover, as was their custom. After the feast ended, while the caravan from Nazareth was returning home, Joseph and Mary assumed that Jesus was traveling with relatives or acquaintances. However, after a full day’s journey, they realized He was not with them.

Distressed, they returned to Jerusalem and searched for Him for three days. Finally, “they found Him in the Temple, sitting among the teachers, listening to them and asking them questions” (2:46). All who heard Him were amazed at His understanding and His answers (2:47).

When His parents saw Him, Mary said:

“Son, why have You treated us this way? Behold, Your father and I have sought You anxiously.”

Jesus replied with His first recorded words:

“Why were you looking for Me? Did you not know that I must be about My Father’s business?” (2:49).

They did not understand what He meant. Yet Jesus went down with them to Nazareth and “was subject to them” (2:51)—that is, He obeyed His parents. And His mother kept all these things in her heart.

This passage is extraordinarily rich.

First, it reveals Jesus’ early self-awareness regarding His identity and mission. He refers to the Temple as “My Father’s” house, indicating that He understood a unique filial relationship with God. At twelve years old—an age approaching Jewish religious maturity (the bar mitzvah at thirteen)—Jesus already prioritized His divine vocation, though He subsequently returned to familial obedience. The balance is remarkable: this is not rebellion, but clarification of ultimate loyalty.

Augustine commented that Jesus was teaching His parents that He had a greater Father to whom He owed absolute fidelity.

Second, the episode highlights Jesus’ extraordinary wisdom as an adolescent. The teachers in the Temple were astonished. This can be seen as a foretaste of the teaching authority He would manifest in adulthood. For Luke, the event anticipates the tension Mary and others would later experience in following Jesus—echoing Simeon’s prophecy that a sword would pierce Mary’s soul. Here Mary experiences anxiety yet gradually comes to a deeper understanding of her Son’s mystery.

Theologically, the Church emphasizes that even at twelve, Jesus did not sin by “remaining behind.” Rather, He acted in obedience to His heavenly Father. Nevertheless, He returned with His earthly parents, demonstrating humility and sanctifying filial obedience.

Catholic interpretation often notes that Mary and Joseph did not instantly understand everything; they too walked by faith, growing in comprehension of Jesus’ role. Messianic believers may see in this episode a vivid picture of Jesus’ love for the Torah—engaging in serious discussion with the teachers in the Temple—fully immersed in Jewish piety and devotion.

6.4 The “Hidden Years” and Their Meaning

After the episode in the Temple, the Gospels provide no further information until Jesus appears at about thirty years of age to be baptized. What occurred during those nearly two decades?

We can reasonably infer several things.

Jesus likely continued working with Joseph until Joseph's death. Joseph is not mentioned during Jesus' public ministry, and on the cross Jesus entrusts His mother to the apostle John (John 19:26–27), which strongly suggests that Mary was a widow and that Jesus, as the eldest son, had assumed responsibility for her care. At some point, therefore, Jesus would have taken on the role of provider for the household.

This context sheds light on certain Gospel details. In Mark 3:21, it is implied that members of His family said, "He is out of His mind," perhaps reacting to His departure from ordinary work to begin public preaching. The Gospels also indicate that during His ministry, His brothers did not believe in Him (John 7:5). The later conversion of James and Jude appears to have occurred after the Resurrection. This suggests that in the preceding years Jesus had done nothing outwardly extraordinary that would have unmistakably revealed His Messianic identity to His siblings. His life must have been sufficiently ordinary that His later claims and authority surprised even those closest to Him.

Here we encounter something profound: the hidden holiness of thirty years of anonymous life.

As one spiritual writer observed, "The greater part of the life of the Incarnate Word unfolded in the silence of a carpenter's workshop, in a remote mountain village; this eloquent silence teaches more than many words about the value of ordinary life." Christians have long seen in this a call to sanctity within everyday existence—work, family, and quiet fidelity.

It is also possible that Jesus used those years to deepen, in His human consciousness, His understanding of the Scriptures and the Father's will. Though sinless and filled with the Spirit, His human mind learned progressively. He may have participated in discussions in the local synagogue, or traveled within Galilee—though we have no record.

Some speculative theories (unsupported by evidence) suggest distant journeys, even to Eastern lands or ascetic communities. Such claims lack historical foundation. The most plausible conclusion is that He remained in the region, since the people of His village clearly knew Him well when He began His public ministry.

Chapter 6 Summary

- The childhood and youth of Yeshua were marked by normality and hiddenness. He grew up in Nazareth, in the home of a working family, learning the trade of carpentry from Joseph. He was surrounded by family—His mother Mary, always faithful;

Joseph, righteous and protective (until his probable death); and several relatives referred to as “brothers” who lived alongside Him.

- Throughout this period, Jesus “increased in wisdom and in stature, and in favor,” experiencing genuine human maturation. The only public glimpse occurred at age twelve, when He astonished the teachers in the Temple with His understanding of the things of God, already referring to God as “My Father.” Even so, He returned to Nazareth and lived in submission to His parents, sanctifying filial obedience.
- He spent many years in silence before beginning His public mission. This prolonged hidden life teaches that holiness can be formed in the ordinary: God Himself worked with His hands, obeyed His parents, and served within a local community.
- Later, when He returned to Nazareth as a rabbi, His neighbors would ask: “Where did this Man get this wisdom and these mighty works? Is this not the carpenter?”—a sign that until then they had seen Him simply as one of their own.
- For Christian faith, those years in Nazareth were not empty. They are part of the mystery of the Incarnation, in which the Son of God fully assumed our human condition—without sin—sanctifying and elevating every stage of human life. From cradle to workshop, Jesus lived our life so that, at the appointed time determined by the Father, He might reveal Himself to the world.
- In the next chapter, we will examine that decisive transition into public life: the baptism in the Jordan and the beginning of Yeshua’s ministry as Teacher and Messiah.



Chapter 7: The Beginning of Jesus's Ministry – Baptism, Temptation, and First Disciples

At about thirty years of age (Luke 3:23), Yeshua left the private life of Nazareth and manifested Himself publicly as Teacher and Messiah. His public ministry began with a decisive sequence of events: His baptism in the Jordan River by John the Baptist, His temptation in the wilderness, the calling of the first disciples, and the performance of His first miracles.

This chapter examines each step in that beginning: the figure and mission of John the Baptist as forerunner, and how his baptism of repentance prepared the way; the act of Jesus' baptism and the theophany that accompanied it (the Father's voice and the Spirit descending like a dove); Jesus' forty days in the desert and the satanic temptations He faced; the calling of the first disciples (such as Andrew, Peter, and John), who recognized Him as the Lamb of God and the Messiah; and the first miracles or "signs" He performed—particularly, according to John, the turning of water into wine at the wedding at Cana, described as "the beginning of His signs," and, according to the Synoptics, the initial healings in Capernaum.

We will analyze the theological significance of these opening actions: how they define Jesus' identity as Son of God and obedient Servant; how they set the tone of His mission (a humble Messiah who rejects worldly power); and how the first believers began to gather around Him. We will also briefly note how various Christian traditions commemorate these moments (for example, the Feast of the Baptism of the Lord, Lenten reflections on the temptations, and so forth).

7.1 John the Baptist: Herald of the Messiah

Before Jesus' public appearance, God raised up John the Baptist (Yochanan HaMatbil), His close relative born six months earlier, to prepare the people.

John began preaching in the wilderness of Judea, likely around A.D. 26, with a forceful message:

"Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand" (Matthew 3:2).

He was the prophetic voice after four centuries of prophetic silence in Israel. The Gospels describe him with austere clothing (a garment of camel's hair and a leather belt) and a simple diet (locusts and wild honey), evoking the image of Elijah (2 Kings 1:8).

People from Jerusalem, Judea, and the Jordan region came to him, confessing their sins and receiving from him a baptism in water as a sign of repentance and purification.

John was clearly aware of his subordinate role:

“I indeed baptize you with water for repentance, but He who comes after me... He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and fire” (Matthew 3:11).

He also declared that he was “not worthy to untie the strap of His sandals,” demonstrating humility before the coming Messiah.

Thus, John presents himself as the fulfillment of Isaiah 40:3:

“The voice of one crying in the wilderness: Prepare the way of the Lord” (Matthew 3:3),

and as the promised Elijah spoken of in Malachi (cf. Matthew 11:14). Indeed, Jesus would later affirm that “among those born of women there has not arisen one greater than John the Baptist,” and that he was the figurative Elijah who was to come (Matthew 11:11, 14), underscoring the profound importance of his preparatory ministry.

Historically, even **Flavius Josephus** mentions John the Baptist and his execution at the hands of Herod Antipas, corroborating both his existence and his public impact. According to Josephus, John was a righteous man who called the Jews to virtue and whose growing influence alarmed Herod, leading to his imprisonment and death.

Why was John so important? He rekindled Messianic hope, stirred the masses to sincere repentance, and fearlessly denounced sin—even that of King Herod, for which he was imprisoned. In doing so, he prepared a people ready for Jesus. Several of Jesus’ first disciples had previously followed John (such as Andrew and likely John the apostle).

Messianic Jewish believers see John as a true continuation of Israel’s prophetic tradition—a *navi* (prophet) who bridges Tanakh and Brit Chadashah (Old and New Testaments). Historic Churches commemorate him on June 24 (his birth) and August 29 (his martyrdom), honoring him as a model of repentance and prophetic courage.

7.2 The Baptism of Jesus

In this spiritual climate, Jesus came from Galilee to the Jordan to be baptized by John (Matthew 3:13). The scene is striking: the Sinless One stands in line with sinners, demonstrating total solidarity with humanity.

John initially objected:

“I need to be baptized by You, and do You come to me?” (Matthew 3:14).

Jesus replied:

“Let it be so now, for thus it is fitting for us to fulfill all righteousness” (3:15).

With this response, He affirms that this act aligns with the Father's will and marks the proper beginning of His mission.

When Jesus was baptized, something extraordinary occurred:

"When Jesus came up from the water, behold, the heavens were opened to Him, and He saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove and coming upon Him. And behold, a voice from heaven said, 'This is My beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased.'" (Matthew 3:16–17).

Here we witness a Trinitarian theophany:

- The Father speaks from heaven.
- The Holy Spirit descends visibly like a dove.
- The Son receives the anointing.

This moment constitutes Jesus' Messianic investiture. As in a royal coronation, the Father publicly declares Him to be His Son (echoing Psalm 2: "You are My Son") and the Servant of the Lord (Isaiah 42:1: "My chosen, in whom My soul delights").

The descent of the Spirit signifies that Jesus is the Anointed One—*Messiah* literally meaning "anointed"—empowered by the Spirit of God. Some theologians compare this to priestly anointing or prophetic commissioning. In any case, it marks the formal inauguration of His public ministry.

For Jesus Himself, this was surely a moment of divine confirmation. For John the Baptist, it was the identifying sign, as recorded in John 1:33: "He on whom you see the Spirit descend and remain, this is He who baptizes with the Holy Spirit."

John then proclaimed:

"Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!" (John 1:29).

With this title, he recognizes Jesus as the sacrificial Redeemer—possibly alluding to the Passover lamb or to the Suffering Servant imagery. John testified:

"I saw the Spirit descend from heaven like a dove, and it remained on Him... and I have borne witness that this is the Son of God." (John 1:32–34).

The baptism of Jesus is celebrated by the Church (Feast of the Baptism of the Lord, in January) as the beginning of His public ministry and the manifestation of the Trinity.

Theologically, it raises an important question: Why was He baptized if He had no sin?

Several complementary answers have been given throughout Christian tradition:

1. **Solidarity with humanity** – Though sinless, Jesus identifies fully with sinners, entering the waters of repentance not for His own purification but in union with those He came to save.
2. **Consecration of the waters** – The Fathers of the Church taught that by entering the Jordan, Christ sanctified the waters themselves, preparing the way for Christian baptism as a means of grace.
3. **Example of humility and obedience** – He models submission to the Father’s will and sets an example for believers.
4. **Acceptance of His redemptive mission** – Some theologians see symbolic depth in the act: descending into the water prefigures His future death; emerging anticipates His resurrection. Luke notably mentions that Jesus “was praying” when the heavens were opened (Luke 3:21), highlighting the event as a moment of consecrated mission.

The Church Fathers also interpreted the dove as a deliberate echo of Genesis 1:2, where the Spirit hovered over the primordial waters. Just as the Spirit presided over the first creation, here the Spirit inaugurates the new creation in Christ. The open heavens signal the restoration of communion between God and humanity.

After this event, “Jesus, full of the Holy Spirit, returned from the Jordan” (Luke 4:1), ready for the next decisive stage of His mission.

7.3 The Temptation in the Wilderness

“Immediately the Spirit drove Jesus into the wilderness” (Mark 1:12).

Right after His baptism, Jesus was led by the Spirit into the wilderness of Judea, where He remained forty days and nights, fasting, and at the end “was tempted by Satan” (Matthew 4:1–11; Luke 4:1–13).

This episode is rich in symbolism. The number forty recalls Israel’s forty years in the wilderness, as well as the forty days of Moses on Sinai and Elijah’s journey to Horeb. Jesus, as the New Israel and the New Adam, confronts the kinds of temptations that caused others to fall—but He emerges victorious.

The Gospels recount three specific temptations:

- **The temptation to turn stones into bread:**
Appealing to Jesus’ physical hunger after His fast, the devil suggests that He use His power for self-satisfaction. Jesus responds by quoting Deuteronomy: “Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceeds from the mouth of God” (Deut. 8:3; Matt. 4:4).
He demonstrates trust in divine providence and affirms the primacy of the spiritual over the merely material.

- **The temptation to throw Himself from the pinnacle of the Temple:**
The devil even quotes Psalm 91—“He will command His angels concerning You... they will bear You up”—urging Jesus to test God by performing a spectacular miracle that would publicly validate Him. Jesus replies:
“You shall not tempt the Lord your God” (Deut. 6:16).
He refuses to manipulate God or seek easy fame.
- **The temptation of the kingdoms of the world:**
The devil offers Him authority over all kingdoms if He will worship him. This is the temptation to seize political power by a shortcut—to become Messiah through worldly compromise. Jesus rebukes him:
“You shall worship the Lord your God, and Him only shall you serve” (Deut. 6:13).
He rejects any alliance with evil or pursuit of earthly glory at the expense of fidelity to God.

After this confrontation, “the devil departed from Him until an opportune time” (Luke 4:13), and “angels came and ministered to Him” (Matt. 4:11).

The Significance

Jesus truly faced temptation as a man (Hebrews 4:15: “tempted in every way as we are, yet without sin”). Where Adam fell—through appetite, pride, and the grasping for autonomy—Jesus triumphed. Where Israel failed in the wilderness (complaining about bread, testing God at Massah, worshiping the golden calf), Jesus remained faithful.

This qualifies Him as the perfectly obedient Son and our spotless representative.

The three temptations also foreshadow traps He would later refuse in His ministry:

- He would not reduce His mission to mere material provision (though He fed multitudes, His purpose was higher).
- He would not perform signs for self-glorification (when asked for a sign from heaven, He refused except the “sign of Jonah”).
- He would not seek political domination (He rejected being made an earthly king).

For Christian spirituality, Christ’s temptations model how believers confront their own: through the Word of God (Jesus answers with Scripture) and steadfast fidelity. During Lent, Christians meditate deeply on this passage.

The Fathers of the Church often said that in the wilderness Jesus bound the “strong man” (Satan), anticipating His ultimate victory over evil.

7.4 The Calling of the First Disciples

After overcoming temptation in the wilderness, Jesus returned to the region of the Jordan where John was baptizing. John the Baptist did not hesitate to direct his own disciples toward Jesus.

In John 1:35–42, it is recorded that John, standing with two of his disciples (Andrew and another—probably John the Evangelist), saw Jesus passing by and said, “Behold, the Lamb of God.” The two disciples then followed Jesus. He turned and asked them, “What are you seeking?” They replied, “Rabbi, where are You staying?” Jesus answered, “Come and see.” They went and spent the day with Him.

Andrew became so convinced that he ran to find his brother Simon and said, “We have found the Messiah.” He brought him to Jesus. Jesus looked at Simon and gave him a new name: “You are Simon, son of Jonah; you shall be called Cephas (Peter)” (John 1:42).

Shortly afterward, Jesus found Philip and said to him, “Follow Me” (John 1:43). Philip then found Nathanael (also known as Bartholomew) and told him, “We have found Him of whom Moses in the Law and also the prophets wrote: Jesus of Nazareth.” Nathanael responded skeptically, “Can anything good come out of Nazareth?” Philip replied, “Come and see.”

When Jesus saw Nathanael approaching, He said, “Behold, an Israelite indeed, in whom there is no deceit.” Nathanael, surprised, asked, “How do You know me?” Jesus answered, “Before Philip called you, when you were under the fig tree, I saw you.” That was enough. Nathanael exclaimed, “Rabbi, You are the Son of God! You are the King of Israel.” Jesus replied that he would see even greater things (John 1:45–51).

In parallel, the Synoptic Gospels recount (Matthew 4:18–22; Mark 1:16–20; Luke 5:1–11) the calling by the Sea of Galilee of four fishermen: Simon Peter and Andrew his brother, and James (Jacob) son of Zebedee with John his brother.

As Jesus walked along the shore, He said to them, “Follow Me, and I will make you fishers of men” (Mark 1:17). Immediately they left their nets (and Zebedee their father in the boat) and followed Him.

Luke provides a more detailed account: Jesus was teaching the crowd by the lakeshore and entered Simon’s boat. After speaking, He told Simon to put out into deep water and let down the nets. Simon protested that they had worked all night and caught nothing, but at Jesus’ word he would comply. They caught such a great number of fish that their nets nearly broke.

Confronted with the miracle, Peter fell at Jesus’ knees, saying, “Depart from me, Lord, for I am a sinful man.” Jesus replied, “Do not be afraid; from now on you will catch men” (Luke 5:8–10).

Thus, they left everything and followed Him.

Bringing both traditions together, we may reasonably infer that Andrew, John, Peter, and the others first encountered Jesus near the Jordan through the introduction of John the Baptist. They then returned to their fishing in Galilee, and later Jesus came to them with a definitive call. This explains why they followed Him “immediately” — they already had a foundational faith in Him.

Jesus thus formed His initial circle:

Peter, Andrew, James, and John (fishermen); Philip; Nathanael (possibly a learned man “under the fig tree,” perhaps praying or studying); and likely soon afterward Matthew (a tax collector, called later in Capernaum). These names constitute the foundation of the group of the Twelve Apostles whom Jesus would formally appoint (see the full lists in Matthew 10:2–4 and Luke 6:14–16, with minor variations in names).

The disciples’ response becomes paradigmatic: they left their occupations, families, and possessions at once. In Christian tradition — especially in monastic and missionary spirituality — this scene is seen as the prototype of radical vocation.

Simon’s receiving a new name (Peter, “rock”) foreshadows his distinctive role, later confirmed in Matthew 16:18 as the “rock” associated with the Church. Nathanael’s confession of Jesus as “Son of God” and “King of Israel” shows that from the very beginning some recognized His messianic identity.

It is also significant that Jesus chose ordinary men — fishermen, not scribes or priests — perhaps so that divine power would be manifested through humble instruments. The Gospels indicate that several of these first disciples had previously followed John; the transition to Jesus was natural and, in fact, encouraged by John himself.

7.5 The First Miracles and Teachings

Once He had gathered a group of disciples, Jesus began His ministerial activity: proclaiming the arrival of the Kingdom of God and confirming His message through mighty works.

According to the Gospel of John, His first miracle took place in Cana, at a wedding to which Jesus, His disciples, and His mother Mary had been invited. During the celebration, the wine ran out. Mary brought the need to Jesus’ attention. Though He replied, “Woman, what does this have to do with Me? My hour has not yet come” (addressing her respectfully, yet indicating that His mission unfolds according to the Father’s timetable), Mary nevertheless told the servants with confidence: “Do whatever He tells you.”

Jesus then instructed them to fill six large stone jars — used for Jewish ritual purification — with water. After they were filled, He said, “Draw some out now and take it to the master of the feast.” The water had become wine of exceptional quality. The steward, unaware of its origin, praised the bridegroom for saving the best wine for last (John 2:1–11).

John concludes: “This beginning of signs Jesus did in Cana of Galilee, and manifested His glory; and His disciples believed in Him.”

This sign is theologically rich:

- **Messianic joy:** Jesus blesses a wedding feast — in contrast to the austerity of John the Baptist in the wilderness — foreshadowing the biblical image of the Messiah as Bridegroom.
- **Abundant wine:** The superabundance and superior quality evoke prophetic promises of messianic abundance (e.g., Amos 9:13).
- **Purification fulfilled:** The transformation occurs in jars used for ritual cleansing, symbolically pointing to a new and deeper purification.
- **Mary’s role:** Mary’s intercession and her words, “Do whatever He tells you,” have been foundational in Catholic theology regarding her mediating role. Protestant traditions tend to emphasize instead that the miracle highlights Christ’s authority alone. Messianic Jewish believers may stress the continuity of Jewish wedding customs and covenant symbolism within the sign.

Most importantly, the miracle revealed His glory and strengthened the disciples’ faith. The “sign” was not merely a display of power, but a revelation of identity: the hidden Son of God was beginning to unveil His divine glory.

The Synoptic Gospels, by contrast, present Jesus’ first recorded actions as His preaching in the synagogue of Capernaum and several miracles performed there.

Among them is the expulsion of an unclean spirit from a man in the synagogue (Mark 1:23–28). The people were astonished at His authority, not only in teaching but in commanding demons. He also healed Peter’s mother-in-law, who was sick with a fever (Mark 1:29–31); after being restored, she immediately began serving them. That same evening, the entire town gathered at the door with the sick and demon-possessed, and Jesus healed many (Mark 1:32–34).

Luke adds that in those early days Jesus performed the miraculous catch of fish (Luke 5:1–11) and a striking miracle: the cleansing of a leper (Luke 5:12–16). The man pleaded, “Lord, if You are willing, You can make me clean.” Moved with compassion, Jesus “stretched out His hand and touched him” — the pure touching the ritually impure — saying, “I am willing; be clean.” Immediately the leprosy left him. Jesus instructed him to present himself to the priest and offer the prescribed sacrifice for purification, thus observing the Mosaic Law, and told him not to spread the news. Nevertheless, the report spread, and His fame increased.

Another early event was the healing of a paralytic lowered through the roof of a crowded house (Mark 2:1–12). Before addressing the physical condition, Jesus declared, “Son, your sins are forgiven.” The scribes inwardly accused Him of blasphemy, reasoning that only God can forgive sins. Perceiving their thoughts, Jesus asked, “Which is easier, to say, ‘Your

sins are forgiven,’ or to say, ‘Rise, take up your bed and walk’?” Then He added, “But that you may know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins...” and commanded the paralytic to rise. The man stood up healed, and all glorified God in amazement.

This miracle did more than restore physical health; it revealed Jesus’ divine authority over sin itself — an implicit yet unmistakable claim concerning His identity.

These “firstfruits” of the ministry reveal a clear pattern: Jesus proclaims the Kingdom of God — essentially, the saving reign of God breaking into history — and demonstrates its reality by liberating people from various forms of bondage: demons, sickness, sin, and social exclusion (as in the reintegration of the cleansed leper).

The initial reaction of the people was wonder and enthusiasm: “His fame spread throughout the whole region,” and “great crowds followed Him.” At the same time, questions and opposition began to emerge, particularly from religious leaders. For example, His pronouncement of forgiveness to the paralytic immediately provoked internal accusations of blasphemy, since forgiveness of sins was understood as a prerogative belonging to God alone.

Chapter 7 Summary

- Yeshua began His public life by submitting to John’s baptism, despite being without sin, in order to identify fully with humanity and to “fulfill all righteousness.” In that moment, He was revealed by the Father as His Beloved Son and anointed by the Holy Spirit, marking His messianic and divine commissioning.
- Immediately afterward, He faced and overcame Satan’s temptations in the wilderness by the power of the Word of God, rejecting paths of comfort, spectacle, or earthly power that were contrary to the Father’s will. Having passed this test, He began calling disciples—ordinary men with receptive hearts, many already prepared by John the Baptist. At His invitation, “Follow Me,” they left everything to accompany Him. Among the first were Simon Peter, Andrew, James, John, Philip, and Nathanael, forming the nucleus of the future Twelve.
- From the outset, Jesus manifested His glory and authority through miracles. In Cana, He turned water into wine, revealing His creative power and foreshadowing messianic abundance. In Capernaum, He cast out demons with a word, healed the sick of every kind, cleansed lepers with a touch, and forgave sins—demonstrating that He was more than a prophet; He acted with the very authority of God.
- These initial works established the faith of His disciples (“they believed in Him”) and astonished the crowds (“we have never seen anything like this”). At the same time, they generated the first controversies with religious authorities, signaling the beginning of a ministry that would be both celebrated by the multitudes and challenged by leaders.

- In summary, in these first decisive steps Yeshua revealed Himself as the Servant-Messiah: obedient to the Father, filled with the Spirit, standing in solidarity with sinners at the Jordan, compassionate toward the needy through healing and deliverance, and resolute in fulfilling His mission without compromise. The stage was thus set for the central years of His preaching, during which He would proclaim the Kingdom of God explicitly in word and deed, form His disciples, confront misunderstanding and opposition, and ultimately move toward the consummation of His redemptive work—a subject for the volumes that follow.



Apéndice: Versículos bíblicos sobre Yeshúa y Jehová utilizados en el Volumen I

Below is a compilation of the principal passages from the Holy Scriptures cited or referenced throughout this volume. These texts have been fundamental in describing the prophecies, events, and teachings concerning Yeshua the Messiah (Jesus of Nazareth) and Jehovah (the divine name of God in the Old Testament).

The verses are transcribed in Spanish (Reina-Valera 1960 version or a similar translation) to facilitate consultation. They are grouped by thematic categories, following approximately the order in which they appear in the text.

Messianic Prophecies of the Old Testament:

- **Genesis 49:10** –
“The scepter shall not depart from Judah, nor a lawgiver from between his feet, until Shiloh comes; and to Him shall be the obedience of the peoples.”
(Jacob’s prophecy concerning the permanence of the royal line in Judah until the coming of the Messiah.)
- **Deuteronomy 18:18–19** –
“I will raise up for them a Prophet like you from among their brethren, and will put My words in His mouth, and He shall speak to them all that I command Him. And it shall be that whoever will not hear My words, which He speaks in My name, I will require it of him.”
(Promise of a prophet like Moses, applied messianically to Yeshua.)
- **Isaiah 7:14** –
“Therefore the Lord Himself will give you a sign: Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a Son, and shall call His name Immanuel.”
(Prophecy of the miraculous birth of the Messiah; *Immanuel* means “God with us.”)
- **Isaiah 9:6–7** –
“For unto us a Child is born, unto us a Son is given; and the government will be upon His shoulder. And His name will be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace. Of the increase of His government and peace there will be no end, upon the throne of David and over His kingdom, to order it and establish it with judgment and justice...”
(Prophecy of the divine royal Son who will reign eternally in justice and peace.)
- **Isaiah 11:1–2** –
“There shall come forth a Rod from the stem of Jesse, and a Branch (netzer) shall grow out of his roots. The Spirit of the LORD shall rest upon Him, the Spirit of wisdom and understanding...”
(Announcement of the Messiah as the Branch from the line of David/Jesse, filled with the Spirit of God.)
- **Isaiah 40:3** –
“The voice of one crying in the wilderness: ‘Prepare the way of the LORD; make straight in the desert a highway for our God.’”
(Prophecy applied to John the Baptist preparing the way for the coming of the Messiah/Lord.)
- **Isaiah 49:6** –
“...I will also give You as a light to the Gentiles, that You should be My salvation to the ends of the earth.”
(Prophecy of the Servant-Messiah as universal light and salvation, not only for Israel.)

- **Isaiah 53:4–5** –
“Surely He has borne our griefs and carried our sorrows... But He was wounded for our transgressions, He was bruised for our iniquities; the chastisement for our peace was upon Him, and by His stripes we are healed.”
 (Prophecy of the Suffering Servant who bears sin and brings healing; fully fulfilled in the Passion of Christ, beyond the scope of Volume I.)
- **Jeremiah 23:5–6** – *“Behold, the days are coming, says the LORD, when I will raise up for David a righteous Branch; and He shall reign as King and prosper, and shall execute judgment and justice in the earth. In His days Judah will be saved... And this is His name by which He will be called: The LORD Our Righteousness.”*
 (Messianic prophecy of a king descended from David whose reign will bring justice; it identifies the Messiah with a divine title.)
- **Micah 5:2** – *“But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah, though you are small among the clans of Judah, out of you shall come forth to Me One who is to be Ruler in Israel, whose goings forth are from of old, from the days of eternity.”*
 (Specific prophecy of the Messiah’s birthplace in Bethlehem and of His eternal existence.)
- **Zechariah 9:9** – *“Rejoice greatly, O daughter of Zion... Behold, your King is coming to you; He is just and having salvation, humble and riding on a donkey, on a colt, the foal of a donkey.”*
 (Prophecy of the Messiah’s humble presentation as King, later fulfilled in Jesus’ triumphal entry into Jerusalem.)
- **Malachi 3:1** – *“Behold, I send My messenger, and he will prepare the way before Me; and the Lord, whom you seek, will suddenly come to His temple...”*
 (Prophecy of the forerunner—John the Baptist—and of the subsequent coming of the Lord/Messiah to His temple.)
- **Malachi 4:5–6** – *“Behold, I will send you Elijah the prophet before the coming of the great and dreadful day of the LORD. And he will turn the hearts of the fathers to the children...”*
 (Prophecy of Elijah’s return, understood as fulfilled in John the Baptist according to Jesus in Matthew 11:14.)

Genealogies and Incarnation:

- **Isaiah 7:14** – “...Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a Son, and shall call His name Immanuel.”
(Reiterated for its relevance to Jesus’ genealogy as the Son of the Virgin Mary and “God with us.”)
- **Matthew 1:1** – “The book of the genealogy of Jesus Christ, the Son of David, the Son of Abraham.”
(Opening of the New Testament, emphasizing Jesus as a descendant of Abraham and David.)
- **Matthew 1:16** – “...And Jacob begot Joseph the husband of Mary, of whom was born Jesus who is called Christ.”
(Climactic point of Matthew’s genealogy, noting that Jesus was born of Mary, emphasizing His virginal birth.)
- **Luke 3:23** – “Jesus... being (as was supposed) the son of Joseph, the son of Heli...”
(Beginning of Luke’s genealogy, affirming legal descent through Joseph while implying the miraculous conception.)
- **John 1:14** – “And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us (and we beheld His glory... full of grace and truth).”
(Key theological declaration of the Incarnation, foundational to everything narrated in Volume I.)
- **Galatians 4:4** – “But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth His Son, born of a woman, born under the law...”
(Reflects that God sent Christ at the appointed time, born of the Virgin Mary and subject to the Jewish Law, consistent with the infancy narrative.)

Events of the Birth and Childhood:

- **Matthew 1:20–21** – “An angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream and said, ‘Joseph, son of David, do not be afraid to take Mary as your wife, for what is conceived in her is from the Holy Spirit. She will bear a son, and you shall call His name JESUS, for He will save His people from their sins.’”
(Angelic announcement to Joseph, confirming the virginal conception by the Spirit and the saving mission of the son named “Yeshua.”)
- **Matthew 1:24–25** – “And Joseph awoke from sleep and did as the angel of the Lord commanded him and took his wife. But he knew her not until she had given birth to her firstborn son; and he called His name JESUS.”

(Joseph faithfully obeys; affirms Mary's virginity at least until the birth; fulfillment of giving the name Jesus.)

- **Luke 2:6–7** – *“And while they were there (Joseph and Mary in Bethlehem), the time came for her to give birth. And she gave birth to her firstborn son and wrapped Him in swaddling cloths and laid Him in a manger, because there was no place for them in the inn.”*
(Description of the humble birth of Jesus in Bethlehem.)
- **Luke 2:10–11** – *“And the angel said to them (the shepherds), ‘Fear not, for behold, I bring you good news of great joy that will be for all the people: for unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is CHRIST the Lord.’”*
(Angelic announcement to the shepherds about the birth of the Messiah-Savior.)
- **Luke 2:13–14** – *“And suddenly there was with the angel a multitude of the heavenly host praising God and saying, ‘Glory to God in the highest, and on earth peace, goodwill toward men!’”*
(Heavenly chorus proclaiming messianic peace.)
- **Luke 2:29–32** – *“Lord, now You are letting Your servant depart in peace, according to Your word; for my eyes have seen Your salvation, which You have prepared in the presence of all peoples, a light for revelation to the Gentiles, and for glory to Your people Israel.”*
(Song of Simeon — the Nunc Dimittis — upon holding the child Jesus in the Temple, recognizing Him as salvation for both Jews and Gentiles.)
- **Matthew 2:1–2** – *“Now after Jesus was born in Bethlehem of Judea in the days of King Herod, behold, wise men from the east came to Jerusalem, saying, ‘Where is He who has been born King of the Jews? For we saw His star in the east and have come to worship Him.’”*
(Arrival of Gentile wise men following the star to worship the newborn King-Messiah.)
- **Matthew 2:10–11** – *“When they saw the star, they rejoiced exceedingly with great joy. And going into the house, they saw the child with Mary, His mother, and falling down they worshiped Him. Then, opening their treasures, they offered Him gifts: gold, frankincense, and myrrh.”*
(Adoration of the child Jesus by the Magi, recognizing Him with symbolic gifts.)
- **Matthew 2:13** – *“Behold, an angel of the Lord appeared to Joseph in a dream and said, ‘Rise, take the child and His mother, and flee to Egypt, and remain there until I tell you; for Herod is about to search for the child, to destroy Him.’”*
(Divine instruction to Joseph to protect Jesus by taking Him to Egypt.)
- **Matthew 2:16** – *“Then Herod, when he saw that he had been tricked by the wise men, became furious, and he sent and killed all the male children in Bethlehem and in all that region who were two years old or under, according to the time that he had*

ascertained from the wise men.”

(Massacre of the innocents decreed by Herod.)

- **Matthew 2:19–21** – *“But when Herod died, behold, an angel of the Lord appeared in a dream to Joseph in Egypt, saying, ‘Rise, take the child and His mother, and go to the land of Israel...’ And he rose and took the child and His mother and went to the land of Israel.”*
(Return of the Holy Family after the death of Herod.)
- **Matthew 2:23** – *“And he went and lived in a city called Nazareth, so that what was spoken by the prophets might be fulfilled, that He would be called a Nazarene.”*
(Settlement in Nazareth of Galilee, fulfilling prophetic allusions — netzer / “branch.”)
- **Luke 2:40** – *“And the child grew and became strong, filled with wisdom; and the favor of God was upon Him.”*
(Description of Jesus’ growth in Nazareth under divine blessing.)
- **Luke 2:49** – *“And He said to them, ‘Why were you looking for Me? Did you not know that I must be about My Father’s business?’”*
(Words of Jesus at age twelve in the Temple, revealing His filial awareness of God.)
- **Luke 2:51–52** – *“And He went down with them and came to Nazareth and was submissive to them... And Jesus increased in wisdom and in stature, and in favor with God and man.”*
(Return to ordinary life in Nazareth after the Temple episode, emphasizing Jesus’ obedience to Mary and Joseph and His integral development.)

Beginnings of the Public Ministry:

- **Mark 1:9–11** – *“In those days Jesus came from Nazareth of Galilee and was baptized by John in the Jordan. And immediately, coming up out of the water, He saw the heavens opening, and the Spirit descending upon Him like a dove. Then a voice came from heaven: ‘You are My beloved Son; in You I am well pleased.’”*
(Account of Jesus’ baptism with a Trinitarian manifestation and the divine declaration of sonship.)
- **John 1:29** – *“The next day John saw Jesus coming toward him, and said, ‘Behold! The Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world!’”*
(Testimony of John the Baptist identifying Jesus as the redemptive Lamb before all.)
- **John 1:32–34** – *“And John bore witness, saying, ‘I saw the Spirit descending from heaven like a dove, and He remained upon Him... And I have seen and testified that this is the Son of God.’”*
(John’s confirmation of the Spirit’s sign at the baptism and his certainty that Jesus is the Son of God/Messiah.)

- **Matthew 4:1–4** – “Then Jesus was led up by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil... And when the tempter came to Him, he said, ‘If You are the Son of God, command that these stones become bread.’ But He answered and said, ‘It is written: Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceeds from the mouth of God.’”
(First temptation and Jesus’ response quoting Deuteronomy 8:3.)
- **Matthew 4:7** – “Jesus said to him, ‘It is written again: You shall not tempt the Lord your God.’”
(Response to the second temptation to throw Himself from the pinnacle, quoting Deuteronomy 6:16.)
- **Matthew 4:10** – “Then Jesus said to him, ‘Away with you, Satan! For it is written: You shall worship the Lord your God, and Him only you shall serve.’”
(Response to the third temptation of worshiping Satan in exchange for kingdoms, quoting Deuteronomy 6:13.)
- **Matthew 4:18–20** – “And Jesus, walking by the Sea of Galilee, saw two brothers, Simon called Peter, and Andrew his brother, casting a net into the sea; for they were fishermen. Then He said to them, ‘Follow Me, and I will make you fishers of men.’ They immediately left their nets and followed Him.”
(Calling of the first fisherman-disciples and their immediate response.)
- **John 1:41–42** – “Andrew... first found his own brother Simon, and said to him, ‘We have found the Messiah’ (which is translated, the Christ). And he brought him to Jesus. Now when Jesus looked at him, He said, ‘You are Simon the son of Jonah. You shall be called Cephas’ (which is translated, Peter).”
(Andrew recognizes Jesus as Messiah, and Jesus gives Simon a new name.)
- **John 2:11** – “This beginning of signs Jesus did in Cana of Galilee and manifested His glory; and His disciples believed in Him.”
(Conclusion of the miracle of water turned into wine, emphasizing its revelatory and faith-confirming effect.)
- **Luke 4:18–19** (Jesus reading in the synagogue of Nazareth, quoting Isaiah 61:1–2) – “The Spirit of the Lord is upon Me, because He has anointed Me... He has sent Me to heal the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives and recovery of sight to the blind; to set at liberty those who are oppressed; to proclaim the acceptable year of the Lord.”
(Programmatic text Jesus applied to Himself in Nazareth, defining His messianic mission of good news and liberation.)
- **Mark 1:27** – “Then they were all amazed... saying, ‘What is this? What new doctrine is this? For with authority, He commands even the unclean spirits, and they obey Him.’”

(Reaction of the people in Capernaum after Jesus cast out a demon in the synagogue, recognizing His unique authority.)

- **Mark 2:10–12** – “But that you may know that the Son of Man has power on earth to forgive sins’—He said to the paralytic, ‘I say to you, arise, take up your bed, and go to your house.’ Immediately he arose... so that all were amazed and glorified God, saying, ‘We never saw anything like this!’”
(Jesus heals the paralytic and forgives his sins, demonstrating divine authority before the astonished crowd.)
- **John 1:49** – “Nathanael answered and said to Him, ‘Rabbi, You are the Son of God! You are the King of Israel!’”
(Nathanael’s confession upon meeting Jesus, recognizing Him early with messianic and divine titles.)

These verses — and many others implicitly referenced — form the biblical framework that undergirds the narrative of this Volume I. From the ancient promises to their fulfillment in the person of Yeshua; from the revelation of the name Jesus and its meaning, to the proclamations of His identity made by angels, prophets, disciples, and by the very voice of God the Father; from the humility of His manger to the first manifestations of His glory — all is rooted in the revealed Word of God.

By gathering them here, we enable the reader to verify and contemplate directly the Scriptures upon which every affirmation of this work has been found. A careful study of these passages in their context will deepen the understanding of the life of Jesus the Messiah, whose extraordinary journey we have begun to explore in this first volume.

(Note: “Jehovah” is an older pronunciation of YHWH, the covenant name of God often rendered “LORD”. In the New Testament, many attributes and titles of Jehovah in the Old Testament are applied to Jesus, indicating His divine identity. For instance, Joel 2:32’s “call on the name of the LORD (YHWH) to be saved” is applied to calling on Jesus’s name in Acts 2:21 & Romans 10:13. Jesus is “Lord of Lords” (Rev 19:16) as Jehovah is in Deut 10:17, etc. Thus, verses about Jehovah find fulfillment in Jesus as Lord.)

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Glossary

Yeshua

Hebrew form of the name Jesus. Derived from *Yehoshua* and meaning “YHWH saves.” Used in this work to emphasize the Jewish historical and cultural context of the Messiah.

Jesus

Greek and Latin form of the name Yeshua. Used when the historical, literary, or theological context requires it.

Messiah

From the Hebrew *Mashiach*, “anointed one.” A title designating a king, priest, or deliverer chosen by God. In first-century Judaism, it carried strong political, eschatological, and spiritual expectations.

Christ

Greek translation (*Christos*) of the Hebrew term Messiah. Used primarily in Greco-Roman and Christian contexts.

Jehovah

Traditional Spanish form of the Tetragrammaton YHWH, the proper name of the God of Israel. Used in this work to maintain continuity with classic Spanish Bible translations.

Tetragrammaton (YHWH)

The sacred name of God in the Hebrew Scriptures, composed of four consonants. Its original pronunciation is unknown.

Second Temple

Period of Jewish history from the reconstruction of the Temple after the Babylonian exile (6th century BC) until its destruction by Rome in AD 70.

Intertestamental Period

Historical interval between the Old and New Testaments (c. 400–4 BC), characterized by prophetic silence and profound political and religious changes.

Septuagint (LXX)

Greek translation of the Hebrew Scriptures produced between the 3rd and 1st centuries BC. It was widely used in Hellenistic Judaism and by the early Christians.

Dead Sea Scrolls

Collection of Jewish manuscripts discovered in Qumran (20th century) that provide key information about messianic beliefs and biblical interpretation in the first century.

Pharisees

Influential Jewish group in the time of Jesus, characterized by emphasis on the Oral Law, strict observance of the Torah, and daily religious life.

Sadducees

Aristocratic priestly group associated with the Jerusalem Temple. They rejected the oral tradition and beliefs such as the resurrection.

Essenes

Ascetic Jewish community, probably associated with Qumran. They expected an imminent divine judgment and one or more messiahs.

Zealots

Radical Jewish movement that promoted armed resistance against Roman occupation.

Levirate Genealogy

Jewish legal system by which a man could be considered the legal son of a deceased relative in order to preserve the family line, used to explain differences between the genealogies of Matthew and Luke.

Kingdom of God

Central concept in Yeshua's preaching. Not limited to a political territory but expressing God's active sovereignty over history and humanity.

Baptism

Rite of immersion associated with repentance and purification. In Yeshua's case, it marks the beginning of His public ministry.

Gospels

New Testament accounts narrating the life, teachings, death, and resurrection of Jesus: Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John.

Ancient Historians

Non-Christian authors such as Flavius Josephus, Cornelius Tacitus, and Suetonius, whose works contain indirect or direct references to Jesus and early Christianity.

Bibliography

The following bibliography gathers the principal sources used and consulted in the preparation of this volume. It is organized by categories to facilitate reference and to reflect the interdisciplinary approach of the work.

I. Biblical Sources

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 - Septuagint (LXX). Greek translation of the Hebrew Scriptures.
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II. Jewish Literature of the Second Temple Period

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VI. Linguistic and Cultural Resources

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 - Bauer-Danker-Arndt-Gingrich (BDAG). *Greek English Lexicon of the New Testament*.
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Editorial Explanatory Notes

1. On the Chronological Approach

This book follows a reasoned chronological approach, not an artificial harmonization of the accounts. When the Gospels present the same events with variations in order, emphasis,

or detail, the theological intention of each author is respected, and the most plausible sequence is proposed based on historical, textual, and contextual consensus.

The objective is not to force an exact sequence, but to offer the reader a coherent narrative that reflects how these events unfolded in time.

2. On the Differences Between the Gospels

The differences among the Gospels are not regarded as contradictions, but as multiple testimonies from distinct perspectives. Matthew writes with a Jewish-messianic emphasis, Mark with narrative urgency, Luke with historical interest, and John with theological depth.

This book integrates these perspectives without diluting them, explaining the differences when necessary and allowing each voice to retain its identity.

3. On the Genealogies of Jesus

The genealogies presented in Matthew 1 and Luke 3 differ both in order and in names. Matthew presents a descending genealogy from Abraham to Jesus, organized into three groups of fourteen generations, with a strong theological emphasis.

Luke, by contrast, presents an ascending genealogy from Jesus to Adam, underscoring the universality of the Messiah.

This book adopts the traditional explanation that Matthew presents the legal genealogy of Jesus through Joseph, while Luke reflects a biological or familial genealogy associated with Mary, possibly explainable through the levirate law. This position is presented as a reasonable hypothesis, not as a dogmatic assertion.

4. On the Use of Names and Titles

Names and titles are deliberately employed in their original or traditional forms depending on the context:

- **Yeshua** when emphasizing the Jewish and historical context.
- **Jesus** when engaging with Christian tradition and Greco-Roman historiography.
- **Jehovah** as the traditional Spanish form of the divine name
- **Messiah** and **Christ** according to the linguistic and theological framework

This choice seeks historical fidelity without imposing a single convention upon the reader.

5. On Non-Biblical Historical Sources

When citing authors such as Flavius Josephus, Cornelius Tacitus, or Suetonius, this work does so with critical caution, acknowledging both their historical value and their limitations. These sources do not replace the Gospels, but they provide relevant external corroboration concerning the context, the existence of Jesus, and the emergence of Christianity.

6. On Archaeology and Manuscripts

Archaeological discoveries and manuscripts, such as the Dead Sea Scrolls, are used to illuminate the cultural, religious, and linguistic background of first-century Judaism. They are not employed as doctrinal proof, but as tools for historical contextualization.

7. On Theological Scope

This book does not adopt an exclusive confessional stance. It integrates Catholic, Protestant, Orthodox, and Messianic perspectives, noting points of convergence and divergence when relevant.

The purpose is not to resolve theological debates, but to present the data, the principal interpretations, and their historical impact.

8. On Visual Elements

The maps, timelines, genealogical diagrams, and illustrations included in this volume serve a pedagogical purpose. They should not be interpreted as definitive representations, but as visual aids to situate the reader in time, space, and narrative relationships.

9. Final Note to the Reader

This bibliography is not intended to be exhaustive, but representative of the principal sources that support the historical, biblical, and theological analysis of Volume I. Throughout the text, these works are cited and developed according to their relevance to each topic addressed.

This volume invites the reader to an informed and reflective journey. Readers are encouraged to engage attentively, compare sources, and maintain an open disposition, recognizing that the figure of Yeshua has been—and continues to be a point of convergence for faith, history, and culture.

Appendices

The following appendices complement the main content of Volume I and are designed as reference material for the reader. They do not introduce new arguments but rather organize and synthesize key information presented throughout the book.

APPENDIX A — Biblical Texts Cited Concerning Yeshua and Jehovah

Purpose of the Appendix

This appendix gathers the principal biblical passages cited or analyzed in Volume I to facilitate their location and direct consultation.

Hebrew Scriptures (Old Testament)

- Genesis 3:15
- Genesis 12:1–3
- Genesis 49:10
- Numbers 24:17
- Deuteronomy 18:15–19
- 2 Samuel 7:12–16
- Psalm 2
- Psalm 110
- Isaiah 7:14
- Isaiah 9:1–7
- Isaiah 11:1–5
- Isaiah 40:3
- Isaiah 42:1–7
- Micah 5:2
- Daniel 7:13–14

New Testament Scriptures

- Matthew 1–4
- Mark 1
- Luke 1–4

- John 1
- Matthew 11:2–15
- Luke 7:18–35

Editorial Note:

The references are presented without reproducing the full biblical text. The reader is encouraged to consult them in the translation of their preference.

APPENDIX B — Summary Chronology of Volume I

Purpose of the Appendix

To provide a concise overview of the approximate historical sequence of the events addressed in this volume.

- c. 1200–400 BC — Development of the messianic promises and prophecies in the Hebrew Scriptures
- c. 400–4 BC — Intertestamental Period: Persian, Greek, and Roman rule; formation of Second Temple Judaism
- c. 6–5 BC — Announcement to Zechariah and conception of John the Baptist
- c. 6–5 BC — Annunciation to Mary
- c. 5–4 BC — Birth of Yeshua in Bethlehem during the reign of Herod the Great
- c. 4 BC — Flight to Egypt and subsequent return to Nazareth
- c. 4 BC–AD 28 — Hidden life of Yeshua in Nazareth
- c. AD 27–29 — Ministry of John the Baptist
- c. AD 28–29 — Baptism of Yeshua in the Jordan
- c. AD 28–29 — Temptation in the wilderness

Chronological Note:

The dates indicated are approximate and reflect the most widely accepted historical consensus, without any claim to absolute precision.

APPENDIX C — Reference Maps and Diagrams

Purpose of the Appendix

To gather the principal visual elements used in Volume I as pedagogical and contextual support.

Included Material

- Map of Judea, Samaria, Galilee, Perea, and the Decapolis in the first century
- Map of Nazareth, Sepphoris, the Sea of Galilee, and surrounding regions
- Approximate route from Bethlehem to Egypt during the flight of Yeshua's family
- Comparative diagram of the genealogies in Matthew and Luke
- Visual timeline of the events of Volume I

Editorial Note:

The maps and diagrams presented serve an illustrative purpose. They should not be interpreted as definitive reconstructions, but as tools to facilitate historical, geographical, and narrative understanding of the text.

Closing of the Appendices

With these appendices, the reference material of Volume I concludes. From this point onward, the reader possesses a chronological, textual, and visual framework that enables an informed and contextualized reading of the main content.